JÖNKÖPING UNIVERSITY
Jönköping International
Business School

Behind the Brand: How Employees and Students Make Sense of Digital Branding in Higher Education

Master Thesis Within: Business Administration

Number Of Credits:30

PROGRAMME OF STUDY: Digital Business

Author: Nora Mohamed & Zowda Muhamoud Ali

Jönköping: May 2026

Master Degree Thesis in Business Administration

Title: Behind the Brand: How Employees and Students Make Sense of Digital Branding in Higher Education.

Authors: Zowda Muhamoud Ali & Nora Mohamed

Tutor: Naveed Akhter

Date: 24/05-2026

Key terms: Higher Education, Digital Branding, Internal Stakeholder, Sensemaking Theory

---

Abstract

Background: The growing use of digital communication has transformed how higher education institutions portray themselves and engage with stakeholders. Universities create digital brand images using websites, social media, and online platforms to attract students, enhance reputation, and convey institutional identity. However, stakeholders actively interpret, assess, and contrast these digital representations with their real-world experiences.

Purpose: This study aims to investigate how employees and students interpret internal digital branding practices in higher education. Using Jönköping International Business School (JIBS) as a case study, the research explores how internal stakeholders understand the university's digital image, how expectations are shaped by digital branding, and how the relationship between digital communication and daily university experiences shapes perceptions of authenticity.

Method: This study employs a qualitative single-case study design. Semi-structured interviews were conducted with 16 participants, including JIBS employees and students. A qualitative content analysis of the university's Instagram, TikTok, and LinkedIn communication was also carried out to supplement the interview findings. Sensemaking Theory served as the theoretical foundation for the thematic analysis of the gathered data.

Conclusion: The findings reveal that digital branding in higher education is actively interpreted through continuous sensemaking processes rather than passively absorbed. Students and employees constructed the university's digital image around themes of internationalization, professionalism, employability, and institutional credibility, while acknowledging the selective

and promotional nature of digital communication. When evaluating authenticity, stakeholders continuously assessed how well digital representations aligned with lived experiences. Platform-specific communication strategies produced disparate but complementary institutional identities: Instagram and TikTok emphasized relatability and student life, while LinkedIn focused on professionalism and academic success. By centring the internal interpretive processes through which stakeholders encounter, negotiate, and evaluate digital branding, this study contributes to the existing literature on higher education branding.

Acknowledgement

First and foremost, we would like to extend our heartfelt appreciation to all participants who generously contributed their time, experiences, and reflections to this study. Their willingness to share their perspectives and their openness were instrumental in the acquisition of valuable insights that were essential to this research. This thesis would not have been feasible without their involvement.

We would like to extend our heartfelt gratitude to our supervisor Naveed Akhter for his unwavering support, encouragement, and constructive criticism throughout this entire process. His encouragement prompted us to enhance our analytical skills, consider more critically, and further refine our academic writing. His belief in our capabilities, engagement, and patience throughout the challenging and rewarding phases of this journey are profoundly appreciated.

In addition, we would like to express our gratitude to our seminar group and fellow students for their supportive environment, insightful discussions, and valuable feedback during the thesis process. We were able to enhance and refine our work by considering their perspectives and suggestions from a variety of perspectives.

Lastly, we would like to extend our sincere appreciation to our families and friends for their unwavering support, understanding, and encouragement during this endeavour. Their patience, motivation, and confidence in us provided us with the fortitude to persevere in the face of tension and uncertainty. We are genuinely grateful for their unwavering support and presence during this process.

SIGNATURE SIGNATURE

Nora Mohamed Zowda Muhamoud Ali

Table of Contents

1. Introduction 8
1.1. Background 8
1.2. Problem Discussion 9
1.3. Purpose and Research Question 12
2. Literature Review 13
2.1. Literature Review Method 13
2.2. Digital Branding in Higher Education 13
2.2.1. Social Media as a Digital Communication Tool 14
2.2.2. Authenticity and Brand Perception 15
2.3. Stakeholder Perceptions and Brand Meaning 16
2.3.1. Brand experience 17
2.4. The Internal Aspect 17
2.4.1. Internal Branding in Universities 19
2.5. Sensemaking Theory 19
2.5.1. Key Characteristics of Sensemaking in the Branding Context 20
2.6. Synthesis 22
3. Methodology 25
3.1. Research Philosophy 25
3.2. Research Approach 26
3.3. Research Design 27
3.4. Data collection 28
3.4.1. Semi-structured Interviews 29
3.4.2. Sampling 30
3.5. Data Analysis 33
3.6. Ethical Consideration 37
3.6.1. Anonymity & Confidentiality 38
3.6.2. Credibility 38
3.6.3. Transferability 39
3.6.4. Dependability 39
3.6.5. Confirmability 40
4. Findings 41

4.1. Institutional Image in Digital Branding 41
4.1.1. University Image 41
4.1.2. Academic Experience 43
4.1.3. Managing Expectations 45
4.2. Digital Communication Practices 47
4.2.1. Digital Channels 47
4.2.2. Student-Driven Branding 49
4.2.3. Marketing and Recruitment 51
4.3. Alignment and Authenticity in Branding 53
4.3.1. Branding Alignment 53
4.3.2. Stakeholder Influence 54
4.3.3. Strategic Awareness 55
5. Discussion 59
5.1. Institutional Image in Digital Branding 59
5.1.1. Cues and Institutional Image 60
5.1.2. Expectations and Retrospective Interpretation 61
5.2. Alignment and Authenticity in Branding 62
5.2.1. Symbolic vs Experiential Misalignment 63
5.2.2. Stakeholder Influence and Brand Co-Creation 64
5.3. Digital Communication Practices 66
5.3.1. Planned vs Emergent Branding 66
5.3.2. Expertise Tension and Strategy Confusion 67
5.3.3. Student-Driven Branding 68
5.4. Strategic Awareness and Internal Branding 70
5.5. A Sensemaking Model of Internal Digital Branding in Higher Education 71
6. Conclusion 73
6.1. Theoretical Contributions 73
6.2. Practical Implications 74
6.3. Limitations 75
6.4. Future Research Areas 76
7. References 79
8. Appendices 87

9. AI Declaration....96

List of Figures

Figure 1: Conceptual Model of Digital Brand Sensemaking in Higher Education 24
Figure 2: Data Structure....36
Figure 3: Social Media Comments 50
Figure 4: A Sensemaking Model of Intenal Digital Branding in Higher Education 72

List of Tables

Table 1 Participants Overview....32
Table 2 Summary of Content Analysis....37
Table 3 Additional Illustrative Quotes....57

1. Introduction

This chapter presents the research context of digital branding in higher education, along with an overview of the main concerns motivating this study. It first discusses general tendencies of digitalization and marketization within higher education institutions. It then moves on to emerging concerns related to authenticity and internal stakeholder perceptions of digital branding. Lastly, the chapter presents the problem discussion, research question, research purpose, and the overall structure of the thesis.

1.1. Background

Here is an uncomfortable truth about higher education branding: universities spend millions on digital marketing, yet students gradually trust an Instagram meme from a peer more than an official university brochure (Ratnani, 2026). This scepticism is part of a broader crisis of confidence, with Gallup (2025) polling showing that public trust in higher education fell from 57% in 2015 to just 36% in 2024 before recovering slightly to 42% in 2025.

This paradox lies at the heart of a fundamental transformation in higher education. What was once a nationally focused public service has gradually evolved into an internationally competitive industry where brand perception matters as much as academic reputation (Hemsley-Brown et al., 2016; Brown & Carasso, 2013; Yaping et al., 2023). Global student mobility, institutional rankings, and increased competition for funding and reputation are now defining characteristics of university environments (Stoica et al., 2025; Marginson, 2018). Therefore, higher education institutions are increasingly adopting branding and strategic communication techniques traditionally associated with the corporate sector (Judson et al., 2008; Mampaey et al., 2019; Waeraas & Solbakk, 2009).

The marketization of higher education has been broadly documented. Hemsley-Brown and Oplatka (2015) argue that universities now operate in a "quasi-market" where student choice and institutional reputation directly influence resource allocation. This shift has been further intensified by declining public funding in many countries, forcing universities to compete more aggressively for tuition revenue and research grants (Marginson, 2018; Stoica et al., 2025). At the same time, internationalization has broadened this competition, with UNESCO (2025) reporting that over six million students now study abroad – more than doubling in the last two decades.

Yet competition alone does not fully explain why branding has become central to university strategy. A third force, digital transformation has fundamentally changed how organizations interact with stakeholders and shape their identities. With over five billion people using the internet worldwide (Statista, 2026) and social media widely utilized across demographic groups (Kemp, 2025), digital platforms have become the primary lens through which prospective students encounter universities, current students experience them daily, and alumni remain connected (Zhao, 2024; Perera et al., 2022).

This digital shift has elevated branding from a supplementary marketing activity to a core strategic function. Universities now leverage websites, social media platforms, email newsletters, and digital campaigns to showcase academic programs, institutional culture, and organizational values (Sarder & Mustaqeem, 2024; Barros et al., 2025). Digital branding enables institutions to craft and present narratives about their identity, including portrayals of student experiences, research excellence, and broader societal engagement (Li et al., 2025; Chen, 2022). Through visual identity, messaging strategies, and online interactions, institutions strive to define themselves and strengthen relationships with diverse stakeholder groups (Nofrizal et al., 2024).

But here are the problem universities rarely discuss openly. When digital branding projects an image that does not match what students and employees experience, the result is not just disappointment, it is brand cynicism, disengagement, and what scholars call "symbolic asynchrony" (Mampaey et al., 2019) or "brand hypocrisy" (Wagner et al., 2009). The combination of marketization, internationalization, and digitalization has therefore created a new reality for higher education institutions. Digital branding is no longer optional; it has become embedded in regular institutional communication, extending beyond recruitment campaigns to encompass ongoing relationship management with current students, faculty, staff, alumni, and partners (Clark et al., 2019; Khoshtaria et al., 2020). As universities increasingly project digital identities, understanding how internal stakeholders, the employees and students who live with the brand every day, interpret these practices becomes not just important, but urgent. This study investigates that gap.

1.2. Problem Discussion

While the strategic importance of digital branding in higher education is widely recognized, existing research reveals a significant oversight rather than a single critical tension. On one hand, scholars highlight the advantages: digital branding increases visibility, aids in student

recruitment, and allows institutions to distinguish themselves in competitive global markets (Nofrizal et al., 2024; Li et al., 2025; Demirer, 2025). On the other hand, researchers increasingly acknowledge that branding entails significant risks, especially when projected images do not align with internal realities (Girardin et al., 2023; Foroudi et al., 2020; Mampaey et al., 2019). This gap between external representation and internal authenticity is the central puzzle of this study.

Existing research has identified three key insights regarding digital branding in higher education. First, digital channels such as websites, social media platforms, and online marketing campaigns are essential tools for universities to communicate their identity, values, and strategic priorities (Clark et al., 2019; Chen, 2022; Sarder & Mustaqeem, 2024). Second, these branding efforts significantly impact external stakeholder perceptions, notably influencing prospective students' enrolment decisions and institutional reputation (Hemsley-Brown et al., 2016; Khoshtaria et al., 2020; Perera et al., 2022). Third, authenticity has emerged as a key factor in branding effectiveness, with students more inclined to trust and engage with universities that present a genuine and consistent digital presence (Girardin et al., 2023; Othman et al., 2025).

Despite these insights, a significant gap persists. The literature has primarily concentrated on external outcomes such as student recruitment, reputation management, and market positioning while largely neglecting the perceptions of internal stakeholders (Hemsley-Brown et al., 2016; Clark et al., 2019; Yaping et al., 2023). This is a substantial oversight. Universities are complex organizations with diverse internal stakeholder groups, including employees (both academic and administrative staff) and current students, who continuously engage with and interpret institutional branding communications. As Waeraas and Solbakk (2009) argue, branding in higher education encompasses both an external communication strategy and an internal organizational process. However, the internal dimension remains significantly under-researched. This pattern is evident in higher education branding research, where the voices of those who experience branding internally are rarely prioritized.

This gap becomes problematic when considering the concept of authenticity. As defined by Girardin et al. (2023), brand authenticity refers to the "perceived pattern of alignment between an organization's identity claims and the lived experiences of its members." When institutional branding is perceived as authentic, trust, engagement, and organizational identification are enhanced (Girardin et al., 2023; Morhart et al., 2015). However, when branding

communications are seen as inconsistent with internal experiences, a phenomenon referred to by scholars as "brand hypocrisy" (Wagner et al., 2009) or "symbolic asynchrony" (Mampaey et al., 2019), internal stakeholders may become sceptical, disengaged, or even cynical.

This authenticity gap is particularly pronounced in higher education for two main reasons. First, universities are mission-driven organizations where credibility and trust are fundamental to their legitimacy (Mampaey et al., 2019; Brown & Carasso, 2013). Second, unlike consumer brands, universities cannot easily reset their image when authenticity gaps arise, as students and employees interact with the institution daily and can continuously evaluate digital promises against their lived experiences (Chen, 2022; Girardin et al., 2023). A university that projects an image of diversity and inclusion on Instagram while neglecting these issues internally risks not only reputational damage but also the alienation of its community members (Brown & Carasso, 2013).

Despite this, we know surprisingly little about how internal stakeholders perceive and interpret institutional digital branding. The interpretive processes through which employees and students make sense of branding communications remain largely unexplored. This is not only an academic oversight, but it also has practical implications. Internal stakeholders significantly enhance the credibility and effectiveness of branding initiatives through their roles as representatives, ambassadors, and co-creators of institutional identity (Sheikh et al., 2024; Dean et al., 2016). Therefore, understanding how they perceive branding is essential for ensuring that strategies are trustworthy and meaningful within the organization, not just persuasive externally.

This study makes three contributions. First, it extends the higher education branding literature by shifting focus from external outcomes to internal interpretive processes, addressing an area that has been relatively underexplored in existing scholarship. Second, it applies Sensemaking Theory to the context of digital branding, providing a novel analytical lens for understanding how stakeholders actively construct brand meaning rather than passively receiving brand messages. Third, it offers practical insights for university administrators and communication professionals seeking to align digital branding with internal stakeholder experiences, thereby enhancing authenticity and trust.

1.3. Purpose and Research Question

The purpose of this study is to examine how employees and students perceive and interpret internal digital branding practices within higher education institutions. While current research has mainly focused on institutional positioning, reputation management, and recruitment outcomes (Hemsley-Brown et al., 2016; Li et al., 2025), the internal interpretive aspect of digital branding remains underexplored. This thesis aims to enhance understanding of how institutional digital narratives are perceived within organizational contexts by investigating how employees and students experience and interpret digital branding.

To address this gap, this study utilizes a qualitative single-case study design centred on Jönköping International Business School (JIBS) in Sweden a highly internationalized and competitive environment where digital branding is strategically prioritized. Data is gathered through semi-structured interviews with employees (including program coordinators, professors, and administrative staff) and students (at both bachelor's and master's levels). Sensemaking Theory (Weick, 1995; Maitlis & Christianson, 2014) is used as a theoretical perspective to support the interpretation of the findings.

Thus, this study is guided by the following research question:

RQ: How do employees and students make sense of internal digital branding practices within higher education institutions?

2. Literature Review

This chapter offers an overview of the existing literature on digital branding in higher education, focusing specifically on stakeholder perceptions and authenticity. It subsequently examines the internal aspects of branding, emphasizing the role of staff in brand interpretation. Finally, the theoretical framework of the study is introduced through a discussion of Sensemaking Theory.

2.1. Literature Review Method

This literature review was conducted to identify, synthesize, and critically evaluate existing research on digital branding in higher education, with a particular emphasis on stakeholder perceptions and internal sensemaking processes. The literature search was performed by focusing on key terms such as digital branding, higher education branding, university marketing, institutional identity, stakeholder perception, and digital communication. Various combinations of keywords were used, including "higher education" AND "digital branding", "university branding" AND "stakeholder perception", "institutional identity" AND "digital communication", and "internal branding" AND "employees" OR "students". In addition, concepts related to marketisation of higher education and organizational identity were incorporated to ensure a comprehensive theoretical foundation.

The primary scholarly databases used were Google Scholar, Scopus, and Primo Search through Jönköping University's online library. Filters were used to prioritize highly cited and recent publications to capture both foundational and contemporary research within the field. Furthermore, a snowballing technique was employed, meaning that additional relevant sources were identified through the reference lists of key journal articles.

The quality and credibility of the selected literature were ensured by prioritizing peer-reviewed journal articles and well-established academic publications within the fields of higher education research, marketing, and organizational studies. Citation counts, journal rankings, and publication outlets were considered when assessing relevance and academic rigor. This systematic approach ensured that the theoretical framework of the study is grounded in credible and widely recognized scholarly work.

2.2. Digital Branding in Higher Education

The significance of digital branding in higher education has grown extremely as universities strive to compete in an ever-evolving, global, and technologically advanced landscape.

Previous studies on university branding primarily focused on institutional image and reputation, defining university branding as a method for attracting students and positioning institutions within their markets using various communication tools (Hemsley-Brown & Oplatka, 2006; Melewar & Skinner, 2020). Many other studies in the higher education sector echo these sentiments by reaffirming that brand equity and brand reputation are two of the most critical outcomes associated with branding strategies (Khoshtaria et al., 2020; Yaping et al., 2023).

However, a critical tension runs through this literature. One stream of research views digital branding as a strategic tool for institutional control and market positioning. From this perspective, universities can deliberately craft and disseminate brand messages to influence stakeholder perceptions (Nofrizal et al., 2024; Li et al., 2025). In contrast, a competing stream argues that digital branding has fundamentally shifted power away from institutions toward stakeholders. Foroudi et al. (2020) contend that digital branding is not merely a strategic communication tool but rather an ongoing and interactive process in which stakeholders collaboratively create brand meaning through their direct engagement with the institution. This debate remains unresolved: can universities control their digital brand, or has the digital environment made brand meaning inherently co-created?

This tension is further complicated by the emergence of digital channels. With the rise of websites, social media, and electronic communication, branding has evolved beyond one-way marketing into an ongoing process across multiple platforms (Foroudi et al., 2020; Nofrizal et al., 2024). Accordingly, Buyanza-Mwidima and Nkeni (2021) argue that the focus of marketing in the higher education sector has shifted to more dynamic and digitally integrated strategies. Yet this shift raises an important question: if branding is now a multi-platform, interactive process, how can universities ensure consistency across channels while remaining responsive to stakeholder input?

The answer, according to some scholars, lies not in control but in authenticity. Girardin et al. (2023) suggest that universities that embrace transparency and dialogue are more likely to be perceived as authentic, regardless of whether they fully control their brand narrative. This positions authenticity as a potential resolution to the control-versus-co-creation tension. However, as the next section will show, authenticity itself is a contested concept.

2.2.1. Social Media as a Digital Communication Tool

Social media has become one of the primary channels through which universities communicate their brand and engage with students. Research indicates that universities

utilize social media platforms not only for marketing but also for communication, engagement, and relationship-building with students and other stakeholders (Constantinides & Stagno, 2011; Peruta & Shields, 2017). This suggests that social media platforms serve as spaces where the university brand is conveyed, interpreted, and assessed by stakeholders (Peruta & Shields, 2017; Foroudi et al., 2020).

However, scholars disagree sharply on what makes social media branding effective. One perspective emphasizes content frequency and visual appeal. Nofrizal et al. (2024) propose that frequent posting and visually appealing content enhance student engagement and brand perception. In contrast, Demirer (2025) contends that engagement relies not on frequency but on the quality of interaction and dialogue between the university and students. According to this view, universities that actively respond to students and participate in online conversations are more likely to foster trust and positive brand perceptions than those that use social media solely for promotional broadcasting. This debate has practical implications: should university communication departments prioritize content volume or conversational responsiveness?

A third perspective challenges both views by questioning whether universities can ever fully control social media branding. Foroudi et al. (2020) argue that social media diminishes institutional control over brand communication because students and employees can share their own experiences and opinions online, which can shape how the university brand is perceived by others. This participatory environment means that brand meaning is co-created and negotiated rather than solely controlled by the university. Girardin et al. (2023) support this notion, finding that students often trust peer communication more than official university communications when evaluating universities. This suggests that even the most well-executed institutional social media strategy may be less influential than everyday student conversations online.

2.2.2. Authenticity and Brand Perception

One of the most frequently discussed concepts in digital branding literature is authenticity. Authenticity refers to the degree to which stakeholders perceive branding communication as genuine, consistent, and aligned with reality (Girardin et al., 2023). Research shows that students are more likely to trust and engage with universities whose digital communication appears authentic and consistent across various platforms (Melewar & Skinner, 2020; Girardin et al., 2023).

However, authenticity is not solely created through communication; it also relies on the consistency between what the university communicates and what students and employees experience. Chen (2022) argues that students form brand perceptions based on their overall university experience, which includes digital learning platforms, interactions with staff, and administrative systems, rather than just marketing communication. This implies that digital branding is assessed based on whether it accurately reflects the actual student experience. If digital branding portrays an image that does not align with reality, students may perceive it as inauthentic, leading to negative perceptions of the university (Chen, 2022; Girardin et al., 2023).

2.3. Stakeholder Perceptions and Brand Meaning

Contemporary branding literature emphasizes that brands exist not solely in organizational communications but in the perceptions of stakeholders. In higher education, students represent a key stakeholder group whose perceptions directly influence university reputation, satisfaction, and loyalty (Chen, 2022; Snadrou & Haoucha, 2024). As a result, universities cannot directly control their brand; they can only influence how stakeholders perceive and interpret it (Melewar & Skinner, 2020; Snadrou & Haoucha, 2024).

This raises a fundamental question: how do students form brand perceptions? According to Chen (2022), brand perception evolves throughout the entire student journey, indicating that branding is experienced rather than merely observed. Students develop brand perceptions through multiple touchpoints, including websites, social media, digital learning platforms, and interactions with staff. Similarly, Girard et al. (2020) found that students often connect the university brand to their personal identity and career aspirations, emphasizing that brand perception encompasses both cognitive and emotional dimensions.

Yet a gap remains in this literature. While numerous studies confirm that branding influences student perceptions, fewer explain how these perceptions are formed. Snadrou and Haoucha (2024) demonstrated that brand image affects student choice and satisfaction, but their research primarily focuses on outcomes rather than the perceptual process itself. This indicates that although branding is recognized to shape perception, less is understood about the mechanisms through which students interpret branding messages and construct brand meaning in digital environments. The present study addresses this gap by applying Sensemaking Theory to examine these interpretive mechanisms directly.

2.3.1. Brand experience

The concept of brand experience helps clarify how stakeholders form brand perceptions through organizational interactions. Brand experience refers to the sensory, emotional, and cognitive responses individuals have when engaging with a brand across various touchpoints (Brakus et al., 2009). In higher education, digital touchpoints such as learning management systems, university websites, email communications, and social media platforms are essential to the student experience and thus shape brand perception (Chen, 2022; Girardin et al., 2023).

Henderson et al. (2017) found that students evaluate universities not only based on academic quality but also on digital experience, including the usability of digital platforms and the effectiveness of digital communication. This suggests that digital environments function not merely as operational tools but as experiential spaces where students encounter the university and develop institutional perceptions. Therefore, digital branding extends beyond marketing communications to include all digital interactions between students and the university (Henderson et al., 2017; Chen, 2022).

This perspective implies that brand perception is formed through everyday interactions rather than isolated branding campaigns. As students engage with digital systems, communicate with staff, or interact with university content online, they form impressions that contribute to brand perception. Thus, understanding digital branding requires examining how stakeholders interpret their routine digital interactions with the university not just their responses to marketing communications (Henderson et al., 2017; Girardin et al., 2023).

2.4. The Internal Aspect

While the previous section established that students actively interpret brand meanings, a parallel and equally important question concerns the role of internal stakeholders, particularly employees, in the branding process. Here, too, the literature reveals significant disagreement.

On one hand, a substantial body of research positions internal branding as a strategic tool for aligning employee behaviour with organizational goals. Internal branding refers to the process through which organizations communicate brand values and identity to employees, ensuring that they understand and support the brand (Punjaisri & Wilson, 2011). According to this perspective, when employees understand and identify with the brand, they are more likely to convey consistent brand messages and engage in behaviors that support the brand. Iglesias et al. (2020) argue that employees are not just brand ambassadors but also co-creators of brand meaning, as they interpret and communicate brand values in their daily work.

On the other hand, a more critical stream of research questions whether internal branding can ever be fully controlled, particularly in professional organizations like universities. Sheikh et al. (2024) found that the commitment of academic personnel is significantly influenced by their perception of the brand and their involvement in branding activities. This finding seems to support the strategic view. However, the same study raises an unresolved question: what occurs when employees' interpretations differ from institutional messaging?

Scholars have noted that employees are not blank slates upon which brand values can be inscribed; they bring their own identities, values, and interpretations to the branding process (Riketta, 2005; Edwards, 2005). This is particularly relevant in higher education, where academic staff enjoy significant professional autonomy. Sheikh et al. (2024) observe that when staff feel a connection to the brand and perceive it as genuinely reflected in institutional practices, their involvement and loyalty increase. Conversely, if branding is viewed as a mere marketing effort disconnected from academic realities, employees may feel detached or skeptical. Mampaey et al. (2019) found that when university branding contradicts internal experiences, it can trigger what they call "symbolic asynchrony," leading to employee resistance and cynicism.

This debate remains unresolved. Does internal branding require strategic alignment, or is it an emergent property of organizational culture? The answer likely depends on context, yet higher education contexts have been under-studied compared to corporate settings. Whisman (2009) notes that internal branding research has largely focused on for-profit service organizations, leaving the unique context of higher education under-explored. This gap is significant given the mission-driven nature of universities and the professional autonomy of academic staff, who may be less receptive to top-down branding directives than employees in corporate settings (Mampaey et al., 2019; Waeraas & Solbakk, 2009).

The context of this study introduces an additional layer of complexity. Employees responsible for generating digital content, whether in specialized communication roles or as part of broader academic and administrative duties operate at the intersection of institutional strategy and stakeholder interaction (Clark et al., 2019; Hemsley-Brown et al., 2016). Their perceptions of the brand, their interpretations of what constitutes effective and appropriate digital communication, and their understanding of institutional identity all influence the content they create. As Piehler et al. (2016) argue, employees' understanding of the brand directly shapes

their brand citizenship behaviour, which includes promoting the brand to external stakeholders. In the digital context, this becomes even more important because content created by employees is visible to a wide audience and can either reinforce or contradict official branding messages (Foroudi et al., 2020; Demirer, 2025). This study therefore investigates not only how students make sense of digital branding but also how employees, with their varying roles, expertise, and strategic awareness, interpret and enact institutional branding in their daily work.

2.4.1. Internal Branding in Universities

Internal branding presents unique challenges in universities as they differ from conventional corporations, functioning instead as professional entities where staff enjoy significant independence. Faculty members, administrative personnel, and communications teams may perceive the university brand in various ways influenced by their roles and experiences (Melewar & Skinner, 2020). This variability complicates the establishment of a cohesive brand identity compared to traditional businesses (Melewar & Skinner, 2020; Iglesias et al., 2020).

Studies on internal branding within higher education indicate that staff play a crucial role in how the university brand is conveyed and experienced by students. For instance, administrative personnel interact with students via emails and digital platforms, educators engage through learning management systems, and communications teams oversee social media and websites. Consequently, employees participate in digital branding through their routine responsibilities, even if they are not part of the marketing team (Sheikh et al., 2024; Chen, 2022).

This implies that internal digital branding is not solely the responsibility of marketing teams but is shaped by employees throughout the institution who connect with students via digital channels. Thus, to comprehend internal digital branding, it is vital to grasp how staff perceive the brand and how they convey it through digital means in their daily activities (Iglesias et al., 2020; Sheikh et al., 2024).

2.5. Sensemaking Theory

To gain insights into how employees and students understand internal digital branding practices specifically, the interpretive processes through which they derive meaning this research utilizes Sensemaking Theory (Weick, 1995). Unlike communication models that assume messages are received as intended, Sensemaking Theory elucidates how individuals actively interpret and ascribe meaning to organizational communications, events, and experiences (Weick, 1995; Maitlis & Christianson, 2014).

Sensemaking is a collaborative process where individuals derive meaning through interactions with others and their daily work experiences. Maitlis and Christianson (2014) contend that sensemaking takes place when individuals seek to comprehend new or ambiguous circumstances, such as organizational transformations or new initiatives. This indicates that when universities implement digital branding strategies, both employees and students may interpret these approaches differently based on their experiences and roles within the institution (Weick, 1995; Maitlis & Christianson, 2014).

Sensemaking theory holds significance for branding because branding entails the communication of identity and values, which stakeholders must interpret and grasp. Iglesias et al. (2020) assert that employees contribute to the interpretation and enactment of brand values, suggesting that branding relies on how staff make sense of the brand. Similarly, students understand branding messages through their experiences with the university, indicating that brand perception is formed through sensemaking processes (Chen, 2022; Girard et al., 2020).

This perspective suggests that branding is not simply implemented by organizations but constructed through interpretation by stakeholders. Therefore, to understand internal digital branding, it is necessary to examine how employees and students interpret digital branding messages and how they construct meaning around the university brand in digital environments (Iglesias et al., 2020; Maitlis & Christianson, 2014).

2.5.1. Key Characteristics of Sensemaking in the Branding Context

Weick (1995) identified seven interrelated characteristics of sensemaking. However, for the context of digital branding in higher education, five characteristics are particularly relevant for understanding how internal stakeholders interpret branding messages. These characteristics are not separate elements but interconnected dimensions that collectively enhance our understanding of the interpretive process.

Identity Construction. At the core of sensemaking is its connection to identity formation. As Herrmann (2023) notes, sensemaking often emerges when individuals confront their identity in unfamiliar situations. For students, interpreting a university's digital branding raises implicit questions about belonging: Is this a place where I fit in? Does this brand image reflect who I aspire to be? Employees face similar identity-related inquiries: Does this online representation align with the institution I am proud to serve? Does it reflect my professional identity and values? Thus, the sensemaking perspective links brand interpretation to deeper issues of self-conception, indicating that stakeholders evaluate brand messages not in isolation, but in

relation to their own sense of self (Weick, 1995; Naidoo & Pringle, 2014; Ashforth et al., 2008). When a university's digital campaign emphasizes entrepreneurship and innovation, a student who identifies as creative may feel a stronger connection, while a staff member who values tradition may question whether the institution still reflects their professional identity. This characteristic is particularly relevant for understanding how different stakeholder groups may interpret the same branding messages differently based on their professional and personal identities.

Retrospection. This identity work is inherently retrospective, as individuals make sense of present events by referencing past experiences (Weick, 1995). When stakeholders engage with current digital content, they interpret it through the lens of their historical interactions with the institution previous encounters, earlier communications, and accumulated lived experiences. A new student interprets a welcome video based on memories of the application process and the expectations formed during recruitment. A long-term staff member views a rebranding campaign in the context of prior institutional identities they have observed throughout their career. This retrospective nature means brand perception is never a fresh start but always a continuation of an ongoing narrative (Maitlis & Christianson, 2014; Weick et al., 2005). This characteristic is essential for understanding how prior experiences with an institution shape the interpretation of current digital branding efforts.

Social Nature. The sensemaking process is inherently social, as meaning is created through engagement with others rather than in isolation (Weick, 1995). Brand significance is negotiated in group discussions, study groups, and staff meetings, rather than solely through solitary interactions with content (Maitlis & Christianson, 2014; Sato, 2017). A student's interpretation of a LinkedIn post may be influenced more by the discussions it generates among peers than by the post itself. Likewise, a staff member's reaction to a new digital campaign may be shaped by their colleagues' responses during a team meeting. This social dimension ensures that brand meaning is continuously renegotiated within interpretive communities instead of being determined individually. As Brown et al. (2015) emphasize, sensemaking is fundamentally a social process that unfolds through conversation, narrative, and dialogue, not through isolated cognitive activity. This characteristic is critical for understanding how peer communication and word-of-mouth influence brand perceptions in higher education.

Extracted Cues. In the process of sensemaking, stakeholders do not process all available information equally. Instead, sensemaking focuses on specific cues, elements that stand out and serve as the basis for interpretation (Weick, 1995). A striking image, an attention-grabbing headline, a notable quote from a faculty member, or even the absence of expected content can influence subsequent sensemaking. For instance, one prospective student might extract a cue related to career opportunities from a post about a guest lecture, while another might focus on the university's international character if the speaker's global affiliation is emphasized, leading to fundamentally different interpretations of the institution's identity. These extracted cues become anchors around which broader narratives are constructed. As Starbuck and Milliken (1988) note, what organizational members notice and how they interpret it shapes their entire understanding of organizational reality, making cue extraction a critical but often overlooked aspect of perception. This characteristic is particularly relevant for understanding how specific elements of digital branding, such as rankings, accreditation logos, or student testimonials disproportionately shape institutional image.

Plausibility. Additionally, sensemaking is influenced more by plausibility than by precision. Stakeholders do not conduct comprehensive assessments of brand assertions against objective benchmarks; rather, they create "good enough" stories that help them manage their connection with the organization (Weick, 1995; Weick et al., 2005; Maitlis & Christianson, 2014). A handful of convincing social media messages may suffice to cultivate a favourable brand image, while a single adverse experience, such as an unanswered message or a mishandled complaint on social platforms, can damage the overall institutional brand. This emphasis on plausibility explains why stakeholders may maintain strong brand perceptions even in the absence of complete information: they have built a narrative that resonates, even if it does not capture the whole truth. As Brunsson (1982) argued in his work on organizational hypocrisy, organizations often survive and thrive not because their communications are accurate, but because they are plausible enough to maintain stakeholder confidence. This characteristic is essential for understanding how stakeholders may accept a degree of idealization in digital branding without perceiving it as deceptive, as long as the overall narrative remains plausible.

2.6. Synthesis

The literature reviewed in this chapter reveals three key insights, two unresolved debates, and one significant gap that this study addresses.

First, digital branding has become an essential strategic tool for universities, particularly through social media and digital communication platforms (Nofrizal et al., 2024; Li et al., 2025). Second, branding is not entirely controlled by the university; it is influenced by stakeholder interaction and interpretation, especially in digital environments where stakeholders can engage in communication and share their experiences (Foroudi et al., 2020; Girardin et al., 2023). Third, brand perception is shaped through experiences and interactions across multiple touchpoints, particularly digital ones such as websites, learning platforms, and digital communication systems (Chen, 2022; Henderson et al., 2017). This suggests that digital branding is closely tied to everyday digital experiences within the university, rather than being limited to marketing communication.

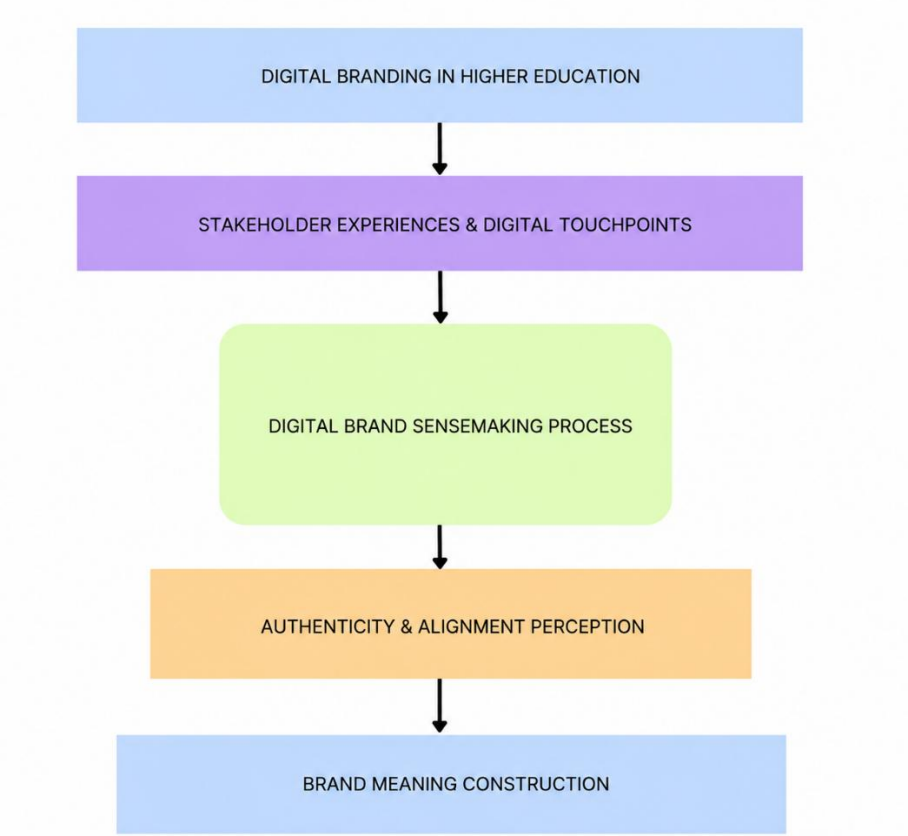
Two unresolved debates are present in the literature. First, scholars disagree on whether digital branding can be strategically controlled or if it is inherently co-created through stakeholder interaction. The control perspective emphasizes institutional messaging and brand consistency (Nofrizal et al., 2024), while the co-creation perspective highlights stakeholder participation and negotiated meaning (Foroudi et al., 2020). Second, scholars differ on what makes digital branding effective. Some emphasize content frequency and visual appeal (Nofrizal et al., 2024), while others advocate for the importance of interaction quality and responsiveness (Demirer, 2025). These debates remain unresolved, particularly in the context of higher education.

Despite the insights summarized above, a significant gap remains. While the literature indicates that digital branding influences perception and that employees play a role in branding, there is limited research on how employees and students interpret and make sense of internal digital branding in digital environments. Most studies concentrate on external branding and student perceptions, while fewer examine internal stakeholders and the interpretive processes through which branding is understood within the organization. Specifically, existing research has not adequately addressed: (1) how employees with different professional roles and expertise levels interpret the same digital branding messages, (2) how strategic awareness (or lack thereof) shapes stakeholder interpretations, and (3) how the sensemaking process unfolds when digital branding messages conflict with lived organizational experiences.

To fill this gap, the present study adopts Sensemaking Theory (Weick, 1995; Maitlis & Christianson, 2014) as its theoretical framework. This approach shifts the focus from how universities communicate branding messages to how employees and students interpret, understand, and construct meaning from those messages in their everyday organizational

environment. Rather than questioning whether digital branding is effective or authentic, this study explores how stakeholders make sense of it, what cues they notice, how they connect those cues to past experiences, how social interactions shape their interpretations, and how these interpretations evolve over time. This processual focus represents a departure from most existing research, which has concentrated on outcomes rather than mechanisms.

Figure 1: Conceptual Model of Digital Brand Sensemaking in Higher Education (N & Z, 2026)



3. Methodology

This chapter presents the methodological framework of the study and the rationale for the selected research design. It first outlines the research's philosophical stance, then goes on to discuss the research approach, overall design, and justifies the choice of an interpretivist perspective. The research context, sampling strategy, data collection methods, and data analysis processes are then covered in this chapter. The chapter concludes with a discussion of ethical considerations and measures taken to guarantee the trustworthiness and research quality.

3.1. Research Philosophy

In qualitative research, philosophical assumptions influence how researchers perceive reality, produce knowledge, and collect and analyse evidence (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021; Boswell & Babchuk, 2022). The researchers' approach to understanding internal stakeholders' perceptions of digital branding is guided by the two key philosophical dimensions of ontology and epistemology, which form the foundation of this study. Ontology pertains to the assumptions about the nature of reality and what is believed to exist within the social world.

The ontological position adopted in this study is relativist, which posits that reality is multiple and socially constructed rather than singular and objective (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). As this research investigates how employees and students interpret digital branding strategies at JIBS, it acknowledges that there is no singular, cohesive reality regarding these interpretations. Instead, individuals' experiences, roles within the organization, and interactions with digital communication shape their understanding of reality. Depending on their involvement, expectations, and personal experiences, employees and students may have differing interpretations of the institution's digital branding. Consequently, each perspective is considered valid within its own context.

On the other hand, epistemology concerns what constitutes valid knowledge and how it can be acquired. The interpretivist epistemological approach employed in this study emphasizes understanding the interpretations individuals make of their experiences in specific social contexts (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). In addition to being a strategic communication tool, digital branding in higher education is a socially constructed phenomenon that internal stakeholders perceive and interpret in diverse ways. Thus, interpretivism is appropriate as it

allows for an in-depth investigation of how employees and students interpret and ascribe meaning to the organization's digital branding strategies.

Interpretivism prioritizes personal experiences and subjective meanings, while positivism relies on quantifiable evidence to draw objective and generalizable conclusions (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021; Pervin & Mokhtar, 2022). This aligns with the study's use of semi-structured interviews, which offer the flexibility to thoroughly explore participants' perspectives, interpretations, and experiences. Moreover, by allowing themes to emerge from the data rather than testing preconceived hypotheses, this philosophical stance supports the exploratory nature of the research (Creswell, 2014; Easterby-Smith et al., 2021).

In line with this interpretivist perspective, it is crucial to recognize the positionality of the researchers. Both researchers are students at JIBS, which provides privileged access and contextual depth (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021; Saunders et al., 2023), but also introduces risks of over-familiarity and bias. To mitigate these risks, we maintain explicit reflexivity, seek disconfirming evidence, engage in peer debriefing with external colleagues, and ensure transparency in reporting by using direct participant quotes (Eisenhardt, 1989; Lincoln & Guba, 1985; Alvesson & Sköldberg, 2017; Creswell & Poth, 2018). By actively managing our positionality (Berger, 2015), we aim to leverage the benefits of insider research while minimizing its potential biases and limitations (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021).

3.2. Research Approach

This study adopts an abductive research approach, which moves iteratively between theory and empirical data (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). While pure induction would avoid any pre-existing theoretical framework, our study is guided by Sensemaking Theory (Weick, 1995; Maitlis & Christianson, 2014), which informed the interview guide and initial coding structure. However, rather than testing predetermined hypotheses, we remained open to themes emerging from the data that extended, refined, or challenged theoretical assumptions.

This abductive logic is well-suited to exploratory research on internal digital branding, a context where existing theory provides useful concepts (sensemaking, extracted cues, plausibility) but cannot predict how employees and students will interpret branding in their specific institutional setting. Data was gathered through semi-structured interviews, allowing participants to introduce unexpected themes. Analysis followed Braun and Clarke's (2006) thematic approach, but codes and themes were continuously compared against Sensemaking Theory in an iterative dialogue between data and theory (Saunders et al., 2019).

Additionally, the interpretivist perspective of this study, which emphasizes understanding social processes from participants' perspectives, aligns strongly with the inductive approach (Guba & Lincoln, 1994). A more sophisticated understanding of digital branding as an internal organizational activity is made possible by allowing themes and patterns to emerge from the data through a systematic analysis of participants' viewpoints (Smith & Shinebourne, 2012).

3.3. Research Design

In research design, the choice between exploratory and conclusive study designs is critical. While exploratory research seeks to provide in-depth insights into a phenomenon, particularly in areas where prior knowledge is limited, conclusive research aims to test specific hypotheses or offer definitive answers to clearly defined problems (Bryman & Bell, 2015). For this research, which investigates how employees and students at Jönköping International Business School perceive and understand digital branding strategies, an exploratory research design is most appropriate. The study aims to explore the deeper, subjective meanings that internal stakeholders associate with the institution's digital communication and branding activities, rather than establishing causal links between variables. Organizational roles, personal experiences, and interactions with institutional communication all contribute to the complex and context-dependent nature of digital branding in higher education (Tierney & Lanford, 2017). Demonstrating causal links by controlling for other factors is beyond the scope and nature of this study.

To capture this complexity, the study employs a single case study design with two embedded units: students and employees. This embedded design acknowledges that students and employees represent distinct yet interconnected stakeholder groups within the same institutional context, each with unique perspectives, roles, and interpretive frameworks regarding digital branding. By treating them as separate units of analysis within a single case, the study facilitates comparisons across groups while maintaining a focus on the shared institutional context of JIBS (Yin, 2018). This approach is particularly valuable for understanding how different internal stakeholder groups interpret the same digital branding practices, revealing both convergent and divergent patterns of interpretation.

Rather than adopting a purely inductive or deductive approach, the research utilizes an abductive methodology, moving iteratively between emerging themes and Sensemaking Theory (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021; Dubois & Gadde, 2002). This methodology allowed patterns to emerge from the interview data while continuously comparing them against

theoretical concepts such as plausibility, extracted cues, retrospection, and identity construction.

3.4. Data collection

This research study employed qualitative data collection through semi-structured interviews to understand how internal stakeholders interpret digital branding strategies. In line with the interpretivist research approach, qualitative interviews allow researchers to explore participants' experiences, perceptions, and interpretations of a particular phenomenon in significant detail (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). By focusing on the viewpoints of employees and students, this approach facilitates insights into how internal stakeholders interpret and engage with the institution's digital branding practices.

Semi-structured interviews were chosen as the method of data collection for this study because they provide a balance between structured guidance and flexibility. These interviews enable researchers to prepare a set of broad, open-ended guiding questions while allowing participants the freedom to express their thoughts and experiences regarding the phenomenon being studied (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). The semi-structured interview process is also adaptable, giving researchers the ability to ask follow-up questions and explore emerging topics during the interviews, which is especially valuable when researching complex organizational phenomena.

All interviews were conducted online using Microsoft Teams and were audio recorded with the participants' permission to facilitate analysis during the transcription process. By utilizing one-on-one interviews, the researchers captured individual participant perspectives while minimizing the influence of group dynamics on participants (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021).

In addition to interviews, this study also collected content from Jönköping University's public social media platforms specifically Instagram, TikTok, and LinkedIn. This collection of content served as a complementary data source, allowing researchers to compare what internal stakeholders reported about digital branding practices with what the institution posted over time. This triangulation enhanced the credibility of the findings and helped identify areas where interview perceptions aligned with or diverged from observable online behaviour.

3.4.1. Semi-structured Interviews

There are different types of qualitative interviews based on their structure and process such as structured, unstructured, and semi-structured interviews. In line with our abductive approach, we chose to use semi-structured interviews as they give a valuable balance between predetermined structure and flexible exploration (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). When answering how and why questions, the semi-structured interview method is particularly suitable since it enables the interviewer to delve further into the participants' interpretations, meanings, and reasoning (Yin, 2018). Semi-structured interviews provided rich insights into how internal stakeholders understand digital branding in the context of higher education by allowing employees and students to reflect on their experiences with institutional digital communication and branding practices.

Based on the recommendations of Saunders et al. (2019) and Easterby-Smith et al. (2021), we followed a conversational tone and active listening throughout the interviews to establish rapport and promote open discussion. This approach helped create an atmosphere in which participants felt safe expressing their genuine opinions. Additionally, because semi-structured interviews have a flexible format, we were able to modify questions in response to participants' answers while remaining aligned with the study's objectives, thereby allowing dynamic interactions.

An interview guide was developed to ensure consistency across interviews while still allowing flexibility in the discussion (see Appendix 3). Exploratory open-ended questions were used to encourage deeper conversations, giving interviewees the freedom to express their viewpoints without being limited to specific phrasing of the questions.

All interviews were carried out online through Microsoft Teams. Data was gathered through one-on-one interviews, which allowed for a targeted and in-depth exploration of each participant's experiences and perceptions. One-on-one interviews yield richer qualitative data by collecting individual perspectives without the effect of group dynamics, even though focus groups can promote interaction (Saunders et al., 2019; Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). To ensure uniformity among participants, all interviews were done in English. Informed consent was obtained from all participants before the interviews were initiated, ensuring voluntary participation and confidentiality in accordance with ethical research guidelines (see Appendix 2).

The duration of each interview was between thirty and fifty-five minutes, which gave ample time to thoroughly examine every subject without hurrying while maintaining engagement through the conversations (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). In total, the interviews resulted in approximately 12 hours 26 minutes of recorded material.

3.4.2. Sampling

Purposive and snowball sampling techniques were utilized in this study to explore how internal stakeholders understand digital branding strategies. Purposive sampling involved selecting participants based on their direct experience with the institution's digital communication and their relevance to the research topic (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021; Smith & Shinebourne, 2012). Additionally, snowball sampling was employed to expand the sample, where initial participants recommended other potential participants who met the study's criteria (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021; Ting et al., 2025). This approach ensured the inclusion of individuals with significant experiences and facilitated access to relevant participants. By integrating these sampling techniques, the study enhances the diversity of viewpoints while maintaining relevance to the research objective (Baltar & Brunet, 2012).

The study resulted in an asymmetric sample comprising twelve students and four employees. This asymmetry reflects the practical challenges faced during the recruitment process. Although the researchers made concerted efforts to recruit a larger number of employee participants through multiple email invitations, follow-up reminders, and personal networks within the organization, securing employee participation proved more challenging than recruiting students. Several factors may account for this difficulty: Employees often face greater time constraints due to teaching, research, and administrative responsibilities, they may view participation in research as an additional burden on their limited time, and some employees might have been reluctant to share their perspectives on institutional branding due to concerns about confidentiality or professional sensitivity regarding their employer. In contrast, students were more accessible and willing to participate, likely due to their more flexible schedules and a greater sense of availability within the academic environment.

Despite the smaller number of employee participants, their inclusion offers valuable methodological and analytical advantages. First, the four employees represent distinct and strategically relevant roles within the organization: two professors and two administrative staff members from the communication, marketing, and recruitment departments. This diversity of

roles captures perspectives from both academic and administrative functions, allowing the study to examine how different professional positions and organizational roles may shape interpretations of digital branding. Second, in qualitative research focused on meaning-making processes, the depth of insight is often more critical than the number of participants (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). Even a small number of carefully selected employees can provide rich, detailed accounts that illuminate complex organizational phenomena. Third, including employees alongside students facilitates cross-group comparisons within the same institutional setting, revealing how different internal stakeholder groups those who produce institutional communication and those who primarily consume it may perceive digital branding practices differently. This comparative dimension would be lost if only one stakeholder group were represented.

The student participants included both bachelor's and master's students, comprising international and local individuals, which allowed the study to capture a range of perspectives and experiences related to institutional digital branding practices. This diversity across program levels and national backgrounds ensured that student interpretations were not confined to a single demographic or academic stage.

The study's inclusion of both employees and students allowed it to investigate how various internal stakeholder groups perceive and understand digital branding within the same institutional setting. Through internal communications, organizational message, and their roles as the institution's representatives, employees engage with institutional branding. Conversely, students encounter digital branding through recruitment materials, social media interactions, and their daily interactions with the university setting. Incorporating individuals with diverse positions and backgrounds enhances comprehension of the research topic and helps prevents a one-dimensional interpretation of the phenomenon (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). This combination of perspectives allowed the study to explore how digital branding practices are interpreted across different internal stakeholders' groups.

Participants were recruited through email invitations sent to potential individuals within the organization. The invitation clarified the purpose of the research and gave participants the assurance that their involvement would be confidential and voluntary (see Appendix 1). In total, sixteen interviews were conducted over a two-week period in March-April 2026, with each interview lasting approximately 35 -55 minutes. To safeguard the participants' identities, each interviewee was given a unique identifier, and all names were eliminated. The prefix E

(Employee) was used to identify employees, and the prefix S (Student) was used to identify students. The findings chapter also makes use of these identifiers to provide clarity while protecting participant confidentiality. A summary of the participants, their roles, and the length of each interview is shown in Table 1.

Table 1 Participants Overview

Participant Code	Date of Interview	Stakeholder Group	Role/Status	Method	Duration
E1	March 17, 2026	Employee	Programme Coordinator	MS Teams	48m 14s
E2	March 16, 2026	Employee	Professor	MS Teams	50m 28s
E3	April 1, 2026	Employee	Communication Staff	MS Teams	45m 25s
E4	April 2, 2026	Employee	Administrative Staff	MS Teams	47m 30s
S5	March 16, 2026	Student	Master Student	MS Teams	35m 51s
S6	March 16, 2026	Student	Bachelor Student	MS Teams	40m 20s
S7	March 16, 2026	Student	Master Student	MS Teams	47m 18s
S8	March 17, 2026	Student	Bachelor Student	MS Teams	45m 33s
S9	March 18, 2026	Student	Master Student	MS Teams	50m 5s
S10	March 18, 2026	Student	Bachelor Student	MS Teams	49m 22s
S11	March 20, 2026	Student	Master Student	MS Teams	45m 28s
S12	March 20, 2026	Student	Bachelor Student	MS Teams	39m 20s

S13	March 27, 2026	Student	Master Student	MS Teams	27m 55s
S14	March 27, 2026	Student	Bachelor Student	MS Teams	53m 18s
S15	March 30, 2026	Student	Master Student	MS Teams	36m 14s
S16	March 30, 2026	Student	Bachelor Student	MS Teams	48m 25s
Total					12h 26m

3.5. Data Analysis

Analysing qualitative data in a systematic and structured manner is essential to ensure that the findings are credible, well-organized, and aligned with the study's goals (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021; Saunders et al., 2019). This study employed thematic analysis (TA) to examine the interview data. Thematic analysis allows researchers to systematically code and compare participants' responses by identifying recurring themes within the qualitative data (Braun & Clarke, 2006; Nowell et al., 2017). This method was considered suitable for the research as it enables systematic examination of participants' interpretations and experiences whilst remaining aligned with the exploratory nature of the study. The analysis aimed to capture how employees and students interpret and make sense of internal digital branding practices within a higher education institution.

We employed Braun and Clarke's (2006) six-step phase thematic analysis procedure using an abductive approach, iteratively moving between empirical material and sensemaking theory throughout the analysis process. Initial codes were generated from the interview data, while themes were subsequently refined in relation to theoretical concepts and existing literature. The six phases included data familiarization, initial coding, theme development, theme review, theme definition, and producing the final report (Braun & Clarke, 2006).

The interviews were transcribed manually using Microsoft Word and subsequently analysed through thematic analysis. This involved coding the data with different colours to identify significant patterns and meanings in the text. Each colour represented an emerging idea or potential theme, allowing for a visual and intuitive organization of the data. The researchers

read each transcript multiple times to become familiar with the material and to gain a preliminary understanding of recurrent themes and participant perspectives.

Throughout the analysis, the researchers discussed their interpretations while evaluating and coding the transcripts to maintain consistency in the coding process. This collaborative approach facilitated the comparison of interpretations, resolution of differences, and development of a common understanding of the data. Ongoing discussions during the analysis process also encouraged reflexivity, allowing the researchers to critically reflect on their interpretations and remain aware of their roles as researchers examining their own institutional setting (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021).

The analysis was conducted in the following six stages:

1. The first step in the analysis process involved navigating through the chaos by organizing the material and familiarizing ourselves with the interview data. All interview transcripts were thoroughly reviewed multiple times during this stage to gain a comprehensive understanding of the participants' responses. To verify the accuracy and reliability of all recordings, the researchers listened to each recording several times and compared them with the automatically generated transcripts. Corrections were made as necessary in an iterative process to ensure that the transcripts accurately reflected the participants' responses and meanings. Each transcript was examined in detail during this phase, with notes made on recurring ideas and interesting findings. This allowed us to develop a general picture of the dataset and identify early patterns or recurrent ideas related to internal digital branding strategies. These patterns were then transformed into initial codes, which captured specific meanings and recurring language across interviews.
2. After creating the initial codes, we began identifying correlations among them. Codes that shared similar concepts or meanings were combined into broader categories. These categories facilitated data organization and highlighted patterns that emerged across multiple interviews. During this process, preliminary themes reflecting common interpretations and understandings of digital branding in the university context were identified. Our analysis resulted in categories that were ultimately grouped under the overarching theme of Digital Communication Practices.
3. We conducted a thorough review of the preliminary themes to ensure they accurately represented the data. This involved revisiting the transcripts to check for recurring

patterns in participants' responses. To enhance coherence and clarity, some themes were simplified, merged, or rearranged. This iterative process ensured that the themes remained grounded in the empirical material.

4. Once the themes were refined, each was clearly defined and assigned a distinct label. This phase involved identifying the central concept of each theme and its relevance to addressing the research question. The themes were organized to emphasize important aspects of how employees and students interpret institutional digital branding strategies. The final codes under the theme Digital Communication Practices included: university website use, social media presence, online program promotion, student ambassadors online, student reviews and testimonials, word-of-mouth influence, digital events and webinars, marketing communication, and recruitment campaigns.
5. Finally, we integrated the themes into a coherent explanation that serves as the foundation for the findings chapter. To support the themes and demonstrate how the interpretations were rooted in empirical data, we included participant quotes. The results were structured to explain how internal stakeholders perceive digital branding in the context of higher education.

   Throughout this process, the analysis remained iterative, as we continually revisited the data, codes, and themes to ensure that the interpretations accurately remained aligned with the participants' perspectives. Figure 2 illustrates the data structures developed during the analysis.

Content Analysis as a Complementary Method: In addition to the thematic analysis of the interviews, we conducted a separate content analysis of Jönköping University's public social media content (Instagram, TikTok, and LinkedIn) over approximately two years. This content analysis employed a directed approach, using the same codes from the interview thematic analysis as an organizational framework. Each code functioned as a category, and the researchers systematically examined posts, captions, and comments for evidence that confirmed, contradicted, or expanded upon the interview findings. Comments were treated as naturally occurring data and quoted verbatim to illustrate patterns. This dual-method design enabled the study to compare internal stakeholder perceptions (from interviews) with external, observable digital practices (from content analysis). Table 2 presents a summary of content analysis.

Figure 2: Data Structure

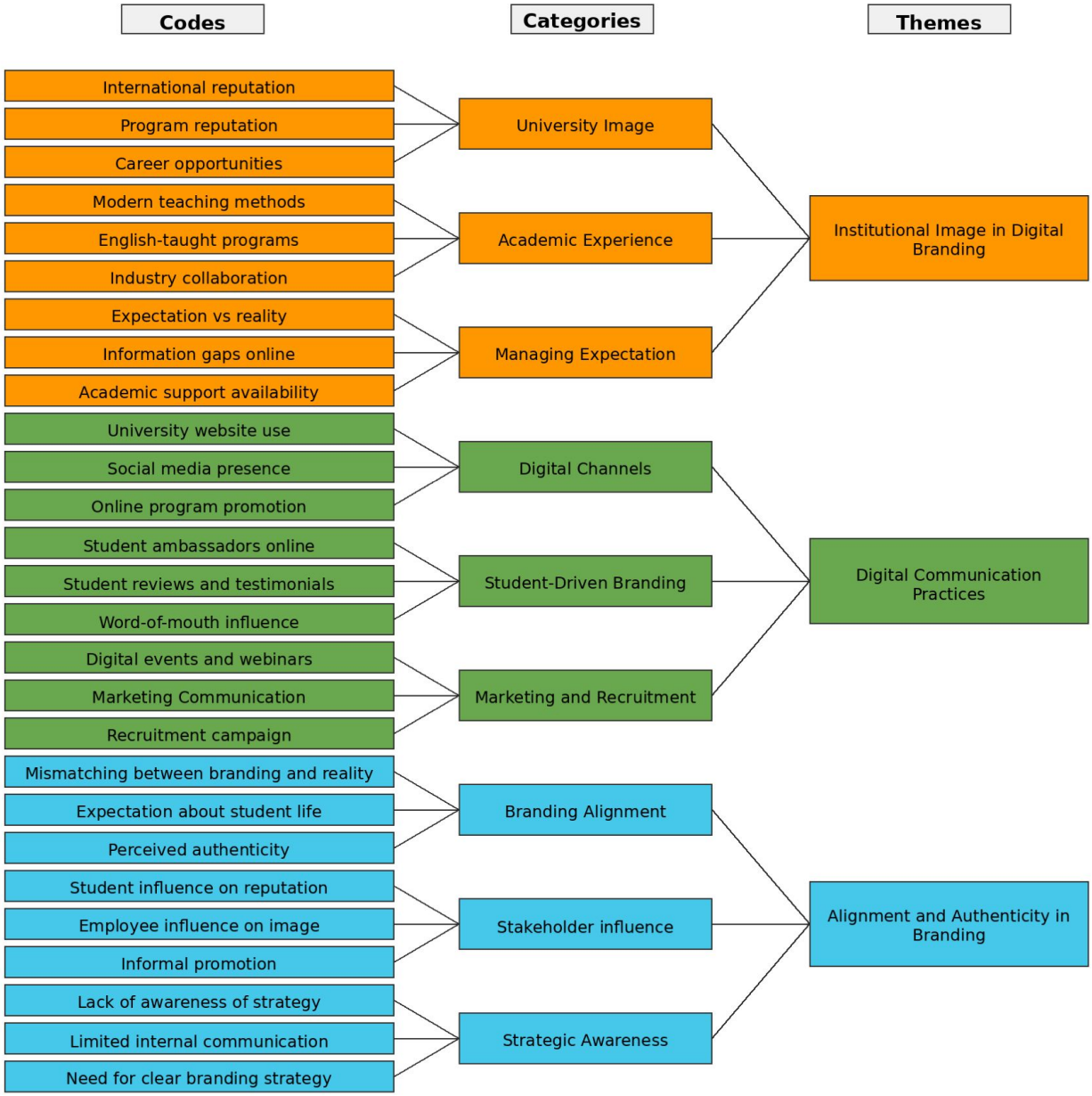


Table 2 Summary of Content Analysis

Metric	Instagram	TikTok	LinkedIn (JIBS)
Tone	Meme / relatable / chaotic student life	Fast-paced, Gen Z humour	Professional, research-focused
Primary Content	"POV", exam panic, Ladok, student ambassadors	Short loops, sound trends, skits	Faculty research, career events, alumni success
Language	Mix: Swedish + English	Mostly Swedish	English (professional)
Target Audience	Current students + prospective (young)	Broad, 16–25, high reach	Alumni, academics, employers
Humour Level	Very high	Very high	Low (warm, not funny)
Engagement Volume	High (many comments, likes, tags)	Very high (hundreds of thousands of views)	Low volume (2–6 comments, 2–6 reposts)
Student Voice	Student ambassadors & memes	Student skits	Faculty / staff voice

3.6. Ethical Consideration

The study closely adheres to ethical principles and research standards, which are crucial for qualitative research, to guarantee ethical integrity (Laryeafio & Ogbewe, 2023). The includes protecting participants' well-being, providing informed consent, and safeguarding their privacy and autonomy (Bell et al., 2019). Ethical responsibility, such as the participants' anonymity was carefully considered notably through both the data collection and analysis phases of this study (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021).

Before and the start of each interview participants were informed about the purpose of the research and reassured that the goal was only to study their perceptions, and that there were no right or wrong answers. Participants were reminded of their right to skip or avoid any questions they found uncomfortable at any time without needing to justify their actions (Bell et al., 2019). An environment of support and non-judgement was fostered during the interview, especially when discussing the perspective of the organization or the interpretation of institutional communication. Interviewers maintained a neutral tone that encouraged participants to share their experiences honestly (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). Informed consent was attained prior to the interviews and participants' privacy was safeguarded using Pseudonyms. All information, including audio recordings and transcriptions, was safely kept on password-protected devices

in accordance with GDPR regulations to preserve participant confidentiality. Also, explicit permissions to audio record the interviews were requested before each session (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021).

Throughout the research process, the study places a high priority on openness and trust, understanding that ethical responsibility is essential to gathering authentic and significant data. The study incorporates both employees and students in the same institutional setting to minimize potential bias and guarantee that a variety of internal perspectives are represented.

3.6.1. Anonymity & Confidentiality

In research, anonymity and confidentiality are essential ethical principles. Confidentiality is the safeguarding of participant data, whereas anonymity is the preservation of participant identities (Collis & Hussey, 2014).

Participants' right to anonymity was guaranteed in this study by a consent agreement that was given before the interviews. Participants were told that pseudonyms will be used in place of their names and other identifying information. This method allowed individuals to openly and honestly express their opinions without worrying about the repercussions for their personal or professional lives.

Confidentiality was maintained by communicating clearly about how the data will be handled and stored safely (Bell & Bryman, 2006). Only the researchers had access to all of the data that was gathered, and it was exclusively utilized for academic purposes. Confidentiality and anonymity are closely related concepts that are significant tools for fostering openness and trust among participants (Collis & Hussey, 2014).

3.6.2. Credibility

The trustworthiness of the data and the degree to which participant perspectives and interpretations are fairly represented are referred to as credibility (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021. According to Korstjens and Moser (2017), credibility in this study refers to the researchers' ability to carry out the investigation thoroughly and provide results that are identifiable and significant to people with comparable experiences.

Both the researchers and the participants were well-prepared, which increased credibility. The literature review and their knowledge with the institutional setting helped the researchers have a firm grasp of the research topic. Furthermore, data triangulation was used by contrasting

employee and student viewpoints, which reduced potential bias and allowed for a more thorough understanding (Korstjens & Moser, 2017). Additionally, both researchers were involved in the coding and interpretation process, allowing us to independently review the transcripts to compare and discuss our interpretations. Through this collaborative approach allowed us to identify potential blind spots and challenge each other's assumptions (Easterby-Smith et al., 2021). In addition, throughout the whole research process, we kept a reflexive approach, continuously reflecting on how our own backgrounds and experiences my influence our interpretations.

3.6.3. Transferability

In qualitative research, transferability is the degree to which results can be applied to different situations or groups (Guba, 1981; Bell et al., 2019). Transferability depends on giving readers rich and thorough explanations so they may assess the findings' applicability to their own situation rather than striving for statistical generalization (Bell et al., 2019).

By including a varied sample of internal stakeholders, including both bachelor's and master's students as well as employees in various positions including programme coordinators, professors, and administrative personnel, this study promotes transferability. The results might be applicable to other academic settings since internal communication and digital branding are important in all higher education institutions.

However, more extensive generalization is constrained by the emphasis on a particular institution and a small, non-random sample. Organizational structures, cultural contexts, and institutional variations may affect how digital branding is perceived. Purposive sampling and detailed descriptions were employed to improve transferability, allowing readers to evaluate the findings' suitability for their own contexts (Drisko, 2024).

3.6.4. Dependability

Dependability is the consistency and reliability of the research process, attained through systemic and transparent procedures (Shenton, 2004; Guba, 1981). Dependability was assured in this study by adhering to a methodical and thoroughly documented research procedure.

Throughout the data collecting and analysis procedure, both researchers worked together, utilizing a thematic analysis approach. To improve uniformity and dependability, a systematic

coding process was employed, supported by continuous discussions to establish themes and improve codes. Transparency was ensured throughout the study by keeping an audit trail that included comments on theme development and coding choices (Bell et al., 2019).

Prior to data collection, the interview guide was reviewed to assure it was clear and consistent. The same semi-structured framework was used for the interviews, allowing for comparability while preserving flexibility for follow-up questions. To provide a precise and trustworthy depiction of the data, every interview was audio recorded and thoroughly transcribed (Bell et al., 2019).

3.6.5. Confirmability

Confirmability is the degree to which participant responses, as opposed to researcher bias or subjective interpretations, influence the results (Shenton, 2004; Guba, 1981). Confirmability was attained in this study by basing all findings on the gathered empirical evidence.

Data triangulation, which compares perspectives from several participant groups (students and employees) to guarantee fair interpretations, was used to support this. Furthermore, by directly connecting interpretations to the source data, the analysis's utilization of direct participant quotes improves confirmability (Bell et al., 2019).

4. Findings

This chapter presents key findings from a qualitative study on how students and employees perceive digital branding practices in higher education. Based on in-depth interviews data, thematic analysis revealed three main themes: (1) Institutional Image in Digital Branding, (2) Digital Communication Practices, and (3) Alignment and Authenticity in Branding. Each theme captures shared perspectives on institutional, communicative, and experiential tensions in the university's digital branding, highlighting broader issues of image, communication, expectation formation, authenticity, and internal sense-making.

4.1. Institutional Image in Digital Branding

The first theme explores how participants interpreted the university's digital presentation, particularly concerning its international reputation, academic quality, and professional appeal. Both students and employees frequently described JIBS and JU as internationally oriented, career-focused, and academically credible institutions. However, the two groups attributed different meanings to this image.

Students mainly associated the university's image with employability, international opportunities, and personal development. In contrast, employees connected the image more closely to institutional identity, organizational reputation, and academic credibility.

4.1.1. University Image

Participants consistently described the university's digital branding as projecting an image related to professionalism, internationalization, and academic legitimacy.

Several students explained that their initial impressions were shaped by the university's website and social media platforms. One student remarked:

> "*When I first visited the website, it gave me the impression that the university is very international with a strong international culture. You see students from different countries in the photos, you read about exchange partnerships all over the world, and the whole tone of the website feels global. That was important for me because I wanted to study somewhere where I would meet people from different backgrounds, not just Swedish students. The website made me feel like I would belong there even though I was coming from another country."* (S5)

Another participant described how the professional appearance of the university's digital presence directly influenced their decision to apply, connecting the visual presentation to their future career prospects:

> *"The school looks very professional and international... I felt that studying here would make my degree recognizable internationally. When I graduate, employers will see JIBS on my CV, and they will know it is a serious school because the university presents itself that way online. That matters a lot when you are competing for jobs in the global market." (S6)*

One student also expressed how the online presentation shaped their understanding of the student body and campus culture before arrival:

> *"The online presentation gave me the feeling that students here are very career oriented. I got the impression that everyone here is ambitious and focused on their future careers, which is exactly the kind of environment I was looking for." (S11)*

Many students linked the university's image to future opportunities and professional value after graduation. The online presentation was often interpreted as reflecting both international exposure and career preparation, with students seeing the digital brand as a promise of what they would become after completing their studies.

Employees also associated the university's image with professionalism and academic credibility, although they described it more from an institutional perspective. One employee, a professor who had been at JIBS for over two decades, explained how the university positions itself within the competitive landscape of business schools:

> *"JIBS has a strong identity as a research-oriented business school. We are considered one of the top business schools in Sweden, with high ambitions and a clear focus on quality research. We aim to be international, which is why being on rankings like the Financial Times is important. We do not really compare ourselves with local universities; our benchmark is other European business schools. That international ambition is central to who we are as an institution, and it comes through in how we present ourselves online." (E1)*

Another employee, who worked in the communication department, emphasized the deliberate effort required to ensure that the digital image accurately reflects the institution's core characteristics:

> *"We are very careful about how we present JIBS because it needs to align with what we offer. The international environment and the quality of its educational programs are key aspects of the brand. We cannot just post anything that looks good. Every image,*

every caption, every piece of content must be considered: does this represent who we are? If we post something that is not true to the JIBS experience, students will notice when they arrive, and that will damage our credibility." (E3)

Thus, employees described branding more in relation to institutional representation and organizational credibility than to personal opportunity. While students saw the brand as a promise of future personal success, employees saw it as a reflection of institutional values and strategic positioning.

4.1.2. Academic Experience

Students frequently compared the academic experience portrayed online with their actual experiences after enrolment. Several students noted that while some aspects of the university's communication aligned with reality, experiences varied significantly depending on the courses and instructors. One participant explained the disconnect between the digital promise and the classroom reality:

"They show a lot about group work and interactive classes online, which is true to some extent, but it also depends heavily on the course and the teacher. Some of my courses have been very interactive with lots of group projects and discussions, but others have been mostly lectures where the professor talks for two hours and you just take notes." (S10)

Another student expressed disappointment that the practical, hands-on learning emphasized in digital communications did not always materialize in the actual curriculum:

"I expected more practical elements because that's what they emphasize online, but some courses remain very theoretical. The website talked a lot about real-world projects and company collaborations, so I thought we would be working with actual businesses every semester. But only some courses have that, and others are just traditional lectures and exams. I still learned a lot, but it was not as hands-on as I expected from watching the videos and reading the program descriptions online" (S7)

Many Students frequently compared the academic experience portrayed online with their actual experiences after enrolment. Several students noted that while some aspects of the university's communication aligned with reality, experiences varied significantly depending on the courses and instructors. One participant explained the disconnect between the digital promise and the classroom reality:

"The student experience presented online focuses more on social life than on academic pressure. You see all these posts about events, parties, and people having fun together. There is nothing wrong with that, but you do not see as much about how hard the courses are, how much time you need to spend studying, or how stressful exam periods can be. I think if they showed more of the academic side, students would still come, but they would be better prepared for the workload." (S13)

Students often formed expectations about university life without fully grasping the academic workload and complexity they would later encounter. This trend was also evident in the digital content analysis. Content on Instagram and TikTok primarily highlighted student routines, humour, campus experiences, social interactions, and emotionally relatable situations related to exams and deadlines. Detailed academic information and program expectations were less visible across these platforms, creating a gap between the entertaining content that generated high engagement and the substantive information that students needed to make informed decisions.

Employees described the academic experience somewhat differently. Several emphasized the need for consistency between communication and actual program delivery, recognizing the responsibility that comes with shaping student expectations. One participant noted:

"What we communicate about programs needs to match what students experience; otherwise, it creates confusion and disappointment. If a student chooses our program because they saw something online that made them think they would get certain experiences, and then those experiences are not there, they will feel misled. That is not fair to the student, and it is also bad for the university because that student will tell others about their negative experience. We must be careful about the promises we make through our digital communication." (E2)

While students primarily discussed these discrepancies through their personal academic experiences, employees more frequently linked them to communication consistency and institutional representation. This difference in perspective reflected the distinct positions of the two stakeholder groups: students experienced the gap between promise and reality firsthand, while employees saw it as a communication challenge to be managed.

4.1.3. Managing Expectations

Many students explained how digital branding shaped their expectations before arriving at the university. Participants often associated the university's online communication with internationalization, active student life, and a dynamic environment. One student described the excitement and following adjustment that followed:

> *"Before coming here, I thought everything would be very international and dynamic all the time because that's what you see online. Every post showed student from different countries working together, professors from all over the world, and events happening constantly. When I arrived, I realized that it is still international, but it is not like that every single moment. Some days are just normal days where you go to class, study in the library, and go home. It took me a few months to adjust my expectations and understand that the online image is more of a highlight reel than a daily reality." (S5)*

Another participant reflected on how the excitement generated by digital content sometimes conflicted with the more balanced, routine nature of actual university life:

> *"The online image creates excitement, but reality feels more balanced. When you are watching the Instagram stories and TikTok videos before you come, everything looks so exciting and fun. You cannot wait to be there. But then you arrive, and you realize that university is still university. The excitement is still there, but it is not constant like the online content makes it seem." (S15)*

Students often described the online presentation as emphasizing the more exciting and socially engaging aspects of university life while downplaying the routine, mundane, or challenging elements. However, many participants did not view these differences as misleading or deceptive. Several students acknowledged that universities, like any organization promoting itself, tend to present more selective and positive representations online. One participant explained this understanding with remarkable sophistication:

> *"I think every university shows its best side online, so you kind of expect that it won't be the same. So, when I looked at the university's social media, I understood that they were showing the highlights, not the whole picture. That does not mean they are lying; it just means they are marketing themselves, and that is what every organization does." (S8)*

Another student similarly noted the distinction between idealized online content and lived reality, while still finding value in the digital representation:

> *"It's not that it's wrong, but it might be a bit more idealized online compared to reality…. Sometimes the Wi-Fi does not work, and it's normal, there would be a gap, and I was okay with it." (S6)*

As a result, students often accepted the differences between online representation and lived experience as a normal part of university marketing and communication. Rather than feeling deceived, they adjusted their expectations and interpreted digital branding through a lens of informed scepticism.

Employees also discussed the balance between attraction and realism, acknowledging the tension between the need to recruit students and the responsibility to provide accurate information. One employee explained the challenge from a strategic perspective:

> *"There is pressure to attract students while remaining realistic. We are competing with other universities for the same students, so we want to look as attractive as possible. But if we exaggerate too much, students will arrive and feel disappointed, and that will hurt us in the long run because they will leave negative reviews and tell their friends not to come here. So, we have to find that balance between showing our best side and being honest about what students can actually expect." (E3)*

Another employee similarly noted the difficulty of this balance, particularly in a competitive higher education landscape:

> *"You want to attract students, but at the same time you cannot promise something that doesn't reflect reality. If you promise too much, you get students who are unhappy and feel misled. If you promise too little, you do not attract enough students. It is a very difficult balance, and we are constantly adjusting our communication based on feedback from current students about what we got right and what we got wrong." (E4)*

Employees often described expectation management as a crucial aspect of communication and recruitment efforts, recognizing that the expectations shaped by digital branding would later be evaluated against actual experiences.

4.2. Digital Communication Practices

The second theme centres on the digital channels and communication practices through which the university's brand was conveyed and experienced. Participants discussed both official institutional communication and more informal, stakeholder-driven communication, such as student ambassadors, peer interactions, and testimonials.

Students primarily described digital communication in terms of authenticity, relatability, and emotional connection. In contrast, employees often interpreted digital communication differently based on their organizational roles. Communication-oriented staff viewed platforms more strategically, while academic staff generally appeared less engaged with institutional social media communication.

The digital content analysis also revealed that JU maintained a segmented social media presence. Instagram and TikTok focused mainly on student life, humour, and emotionally relatable content, while LinkedIn emphasized research achievements, professional networking, alumni success, and institutional accomplishments.

4.2.1. Digital Channels

Official digital channels played a crucial role in shaping participants' first impressions of the university. One student noted the importance of the website as the primary entry point for prospective students:

> *"The website is usually the first thing you check, so it really shapes how you see the university at the beginning. Before you follow them on Instagram or watch their TikTok videos, you go to the website to read about programs, check admission requirements, and see what the university is about. That first impression is important because it sets the tone for everything else. If the website looks unprofessional or outdated, you might not even bother looking at their social media." (S16)*

Another participant remarked on how different channels served different purposes in forming their overall impression:

> *"The website looked professional, but social media made the university feel more human. On the website, everything is formal and structured, which is good for finding information. But on Instagram, you see real students, real campus life, real emotions." (S5)*

Several students also highlighted differences between the university's digital platforms, noting that each platform seemed to present a slightly different version of the institution. One participant described this fragmentation:

> *"Different platforms almost felt like different sides of the same university. LinkedIn is very professional and serious, all about research, careers, and alumni success. Instagram is more fun and casual, with lots of student takeovers and event photos. TikTok is even more informal, with memes and jokes and trends. It's almost like each platform had its own personality." (S10)*

Students often associated LinkedIn with professionalism, employability, and academic achievement, while Instagram and TikTok were more closely linked to student life, emotional relatability, and social belonging. This platform segmentation meant that different stakeholders might have very different perceptions of the university depending on which platforms they primarily used.

This distinction was also evident in the digital content analysis. Communication on Instagram and TikTok heavily relied on short-form videos, humour, memes, student ambassadors, and emotionally relatable content related to student routines, grades, deadlines, and campus life. Audience interaction was highly participatory, with students frequently tagging friends, using emojis, and responding with shared jokes and experiences. Conversely, LinkedIn communication focused more on institutional partnerships, research achievements, career fairs, alumni success, and professional networking. Interaction on LinkedIn was generally more formal and professionally oriented.

Employees also described digital channels differently based on their organizational roles. Communication-oriented employees viewed digital communication as requiring coordination and consistency across platforms. One employee explained:

> *"Everything we put online needs to be consistent, because that's what people will base their perception on." (E4)*

However, academic staff often described themselves as less involved in institutional communication practices. One participant commented on the division of labour within the university:

"Academic staff are not always highly involved in the university's social media communication... So honestly, I do not know that much about what the strategy is." (E2)

These reflected differences in how employees engaged with digital branding activities across the organization. Communication staff saw branding as central to their work, while academic staff saw it as peripheral to their primary responsibilities of teaching and research.

4.2.2. Student-Driven Branding

A recurring theme in the interviews was that students frequently perceived peer-generated communication as more authentic than official institutional messaging. One participant explained the underlying reason for this preference in detail:

"I think you trust what students say more because they experience it and are not trying to promote it. When the university posts something, you know they want to attract new students, so they are going to show you the best version of everything. But when a student shares their experience, they do not really gain anything from it." (S14)

Another student confirmed this perspective, elaborating on why peer content feels more genuine and how it differs from institutional content:

"When you see students posting about their daily life, it feels more real than what the university posts." (S9)

Several students described student ambassadors as relatable peers rather than formal representatives, with one participant explaining how the ambassador programme successfully bridged the gap between institutional marketing and authentic student voice:

"The student ambassadors felt more like normal students than influencers…. They shared both good and bad days, and that made me feel like if they could handle it, then I could too." (S8)

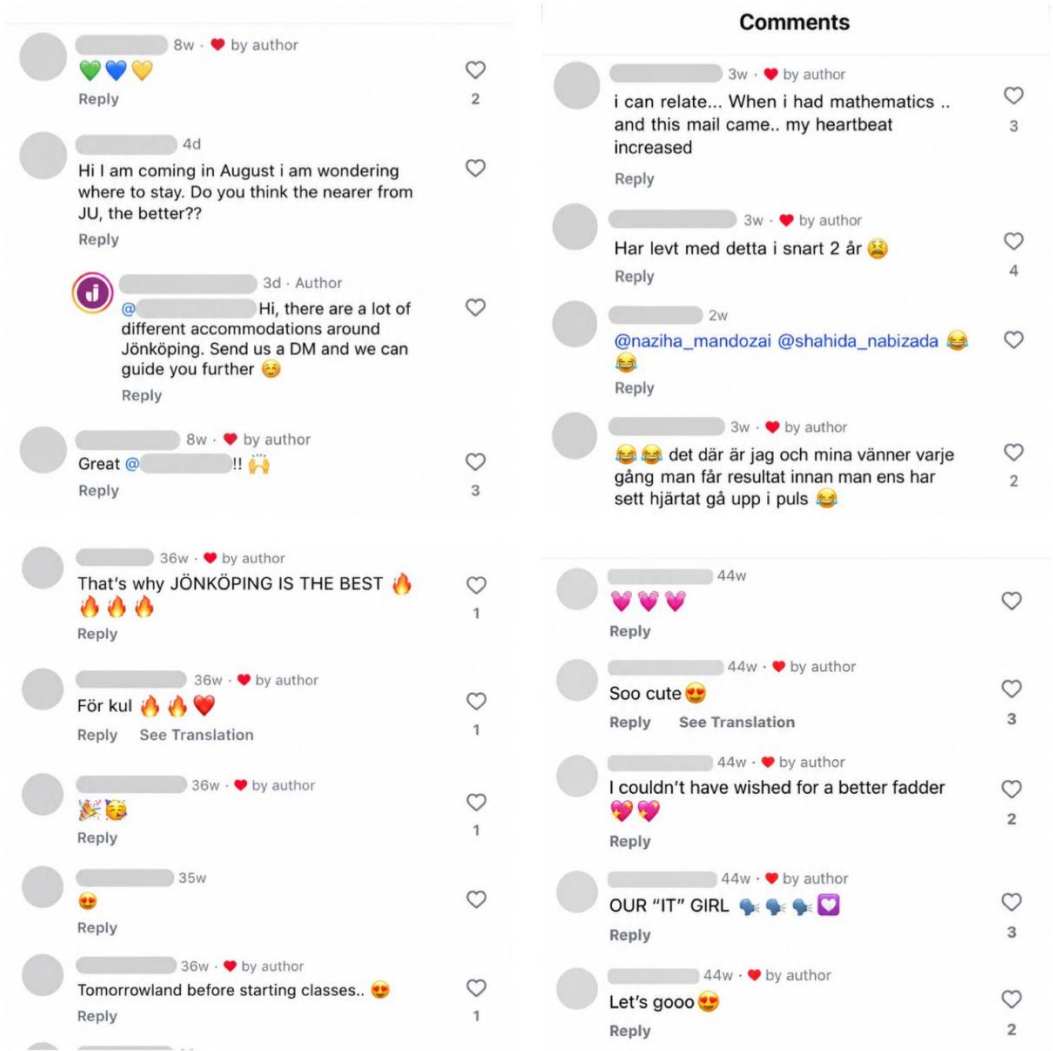
Students commonly associated authenticity with emotional relatability and recognizable student experiences rather than formal institutional communication. The emotional connection came from seeing others navigate the same challenges, deadlines, stress, and social situations that they themselves experienced daily.

This pattern was also strongly evident in the digital content analysis. Student ambassadors appeared frequently across Instagram and TikTok, showcasing everyday experiences related to

routines, expenses, stress, campus life, and social interactions. Instead of presenting themselves as highly polished influencers, ambassadors were depicted as ordinary students navigating university life. The content typically featured authentic, unscripted moments such as studying late at night, struggling with difficult course material, celebrating small victories with friends, or simply walking across campus between classes.

The comment sections reflected strong peer interaction, with numerous posts generating responses where students tagged friends, used emojis, and shared relatable experiences related to grades, deadlines, and academic stress. Comments such as those shown in Figure 3 illustrate how students personalized and engaged with institutional content through humour and shared experiences. (See Appendix 4 for additional screenshots of social media comments.)

Figure 3: Social Media Comments



These comments illustrate several key patterns. First, students actively use comment sections to seek practical information from current students, such as programme details and application tips. Second, students personalize institutional content by tagging friends and connecting it to their own shared experiences. Third, humour and emotional exaggeration (using emojis) are central mechanisms through which students engage with and interpret university branding. Fourth, students explicitly value and praise content that they perceive as authentic and student-driven, indicating that they are discerning consumers of digital branding who can distinguish between institutional marketing and genuine peer content.

Employees also acknowledged the significant impact of student-driven communication. One employee remarked on the power of peer influence and the limitations of institutional control:

> *"Peer communication often becomes more influential than official campaigns. We can spend months planning a recruitment campaign, but then a single student post that goes viral can have ten times the impact. Students trust each other more than they trust us, and that is just the reality of social media" (E4)*

Another participant noted,

> *"Sometimes students communicate the university experience more effectively than institutional marketing because they speak the same language as prospective students" (E3)*

Employees frequently described student-generated communication as both valuable and challenging to fully control. The authenticity that made student content so effective also meant that universities could not guarantee what message would be conveyed. This tension between encouraging authentic student voices and maintaining brand consistency remained unresolved in the perspectives of the employees interviewed.

4.2.3. Marketing and Recruitment

Participants generally interpreted marketing and recruitment communication as selective and persuasive. Employees involved in communication and recruitment emphasized the importance of presenting the university attractively within a competitive higher education landscape. One employee explained the strategic purpose of recruitment communication:

> *"The goal is to show what makes the university appealing and why students should choose us.... so, we have to highlight our strengths, the international environment, the research reputation, the career opportunities, and the student life" (E3)*

Students, however, often approached recruitment communication with a more critical perspective. One participant described how they learned to interpret promotional content with scepticism:

> *"You know that recruitment campaigns are designed to make everything look better than it is…. The photos are staged, the quotes are edited, and the videos only show the best moments. That does not mean the university is bad, but it means you must do your own research and not just believe everything you see in the recruitment materials." (S9)*

Another student added that while recruitment content is useful for getting an initial sense of the university, it should not be the only source of information:

> *"It's helpful, but you always take it with a bit of scepticism. The recruitment materials just give you a general idea of what the university is about, what programs they offer, what the campus looks like." (S12)*

Consequently, students often viewed recruitment communication as useful for initial information gathering while also acknowledging its promotional nature and adjusting their expectations accordingly.

The digital content analysis reflected this trend. Recruitment communication on Instagram and TikTok focused less on detailed program information and more on humour, emotional familiarity, student routines, friendships, and a sense of belonging. In contrast, LinkedIn communication framed recruitment more professionally through alumni achievements, research funding, collaborations, and career-oriented success stories. Different platforms thus emphasized various aspects of university life and institutional value. Several students also described how the strong emphasis on emotional relatability and social belonging sometimes diverged from their later experiences after enrolment, creating a gap between the warm, community-focused online image and the more individual, academically demanding reality.

4.3. Alignment and Authenticity in Branding

The third theme centres on how participants assessed the relationship between the university's digital image and their lived experiences. Authenticity emerged as a significant issue across both stakeholder groups. Students primarily described authenticity in terms of emotional recognizability and personal experience, while employees more frequently associated authenticity with communication consistency, institutional credibility, and reputation.

4.3.1. Branding Alignment

Students often compared the university's digital representations with their experiences after enrolment. One participant explained how they continuously evaluate alignment between what they saw online and what they encountered on campus:

> *"Some things align with what you see online, but other aspects feel a bit different when you experience them. The international environment is real. There are students from all over the world, and you hear many different languages in the hallways. But for instance, how much support you get from the service centre, can vary" (S8)*

Another student noted that certain elements matched reality very well, particularly those related to the university's core identity claims:

> *"Certain elements matched reality very well, especially the international environment. When I arrived, I was surprised by how many nationalities were represented." (S6)*

At the same time, some students described parts of the online communication as more selective or idealized, recognizing the gap between the curated image and the messier reality. One participant explained how they learned to identify when content felt exaggerated:

> *"You can tell when something feels too exaggerated compared to what you experience… Sometimes you see a post, and you think, that is not what it is like at all." (S7)*

Several students, therefore, discussed authenticity concerning whether online representations felt recognizable in relation to their own experiences at the university. If they could see their own struggles, joys, and daily routines reflected in the content, they perceived it as authentic. If the content seemed to come from a completely different reality, they perceived it as inauthentic.

Some participants also identified discrepancies between the university's international image and certain online communication practices. One student pointed out the tension between the university's global branding and the language used on social media:

> *"The atmosphere online, especially on TikTok, presents content in Swedish, but the university is said to be international, so English content is not included there." (S14)*

Students, Students, therefore, sometimes pointed out inconsistencies between the university's international branding and the accessibility of certain social media communications. These symbolic inconsistencies where small, everyday communication practices contradicted the institution's stated identity were particularly damaging to perceptions of authenticity.

Employees also highlighted the importance of consistency between communication and student experience. One participant stated:

> *"Branding cannot be separated from the student experience itself. You can have the most beautiful website and the most engaging social media, but if students arrive and their experience is completely different, none of that branding matters." (E2)*

Employees often described alignment as essential for long-term credibility and institutional trust, recognizing that authenticity gaps could accumulate over time and damage the university's reputation among both current and prospective students.

4.3.2. Stakeholder Influence

Participants recognized that the university brand was shaped not only through official communication but also through the everyday actions and interactions of students and employees. One employee explained how branding is distributed across the entire organization:

> *"Everyone contributes to the image of the university, even if they are not part of marketing. So, branding is not just something that the communication department does." (E2)*

Students similarly acknowledged the role of peer interactions and online visibility in shaping the university's reputation. One participant explained how student experiences spread through word-of-mouth and social media:

"What students share online can really affect how others see the university. I might post about it or tell my friends. When I have a bad experience, I might also post about it or tell my friends." (S6)

This was also evident in the digital content analysis, where students regularly engaged with institutional posts through comments, humour, emojis, tagging practices, and peer discussions. Institutional content often became a space where students shared experiences and collectively reacted to university life, turning official posts into platforms for student-driven conversation.

Participants therefore often described branding as something shaped through ongoing interactions between the institution and its stakeholders rather than solely through official communication. The brand was not a static message delivered from the university to its audiences but a dynamic, negotiated meaning that emerged from thousands of daily interactions.

4.3.3. Strategic Awareness

Participants demonstrated different levels of awareness regarding the university's digital branding strategy.

Employees involved in communication and recruitment generally described branding as intentional and strategically managed. One employee explained the strategic thinking behind their content decisions:

"There is always a strategy behind how we present the university online. We think about our target audiences, we analyse what works and what does not. It is not random. We have goals for engagement, for reach, for conversion." (E3)

However, this awareness was not shared equally across all employee groups. Several academic staff members described limited knowledge of branding strategy, indicating a gap between central communication functions and frontline academic staff. One participant admitted:

"To be honest, I don't really know what their full digital branding plan is. I know there is a communication department, and I assume they have some kind of strategy, but I have never been briefed on it." (E1)

Another employee stated:

> *"I am not so aware of what the strategy is for internal branding. It feels like the focus is on external branding, and internal branding is an afterthought. I cannot really say how that works or what the strategy is." (E4)*

Some employees also described branding as partly shaped through ongoing organizational activity rather than only through formal planning. One participant explained:

> *"Our online identity kind of emerges organically. It's a consequence of what we publish, what the research centres are doing, and what individual faculty post." (E2)*

The digital content analysis reflected these differences across platforms. Instagram and TikTok emphasized student life, humour, and emotional engagement, while LinkedIn focused more strongly on professionalism, institutional achievement, and academic prestige. These differences suggested that the university's digital presence was shaped by multiple actors with different priorities, rather than being centrally controlled.

Students, by contrast, often described branding more implicitly and emotionally rather than strategically. One participant explained that they did not think about branding as a deliberate strategy when engaging with content:

> *"You don't really think about it as a strategy, you just see what's presented… When I scroll through Instagram, I am not thinking, 'Oh, the communication department planned this post to increase brand awareness.' I am just looking at the content and reacting to it emotionally." (S10)*

Another student reflected on how their awareness of branding as a strategy developed over time:

> *"Only after some times do you realize that it's all part of how they want to present the university." (S11)*

Students therefore often described digital branding through impressions, expectations, and everyday online interaction, while employees more frequently connected branding to institutional communication and organizational strategy. This difference in strategic awareness reflected the different positions of the two stakeholder groups: employees (especially those in communication roles) saw branding from the inside as a planned activity, while students experienced it from the outside as a stream of content.

Table 3 Additional Illustrative Quotes

Theme 1	Illustrative Quote
Institutional Image in Digital Branding	*"When we communicate online, we try to emphasize that JIBS is an internationally recognized business school, which it already is. The goal is to show that students who study here will gain skills that are relevant in a global job market." (E4) (University Image)* *"To be honest, part of the reason I applied was that they present themselves as a very international school online, have a reputation for practical projects and student support, which appealed to me." (S9) (University Image)* *"A research-oriented business school with high ambitions and a clear focus on quality research." (E1) (Academic Experience)* *"As academics, we focus mainly on teaching and research…. Communication about the university's image is mostly handled by the communication department." (E2) (Academic Experience)*
Theme 2	
Digital Communication Practices	*"I mainly use LinkedIn to support colleagues by liking or sharing their work." (E2) (Digital Channels)* *"We can be more creative and use humour, which is something we value. We believe communication does not always have to be serious; humour can make it more engaging and relatable." (E3) (Digital Channel)* *"Honestly, I don't think JIBS has a fully developed strategy for digital branding. JU has a communication department, but their work is more general for the entire university." (E1) (Digital Channel)* *"Canvas is my main tool… the JU app is convenient… Outlook is essential." (S10) (Digital Channel)* *"Students' posts, recommendations, and reviews often carry more weight than official channels. Honest, personal experiences influence prospective students more." (S5) (Student-Driven Branding)* *"I actually found JIBS more attractive in person than I had imagined... better in reality." (S15). (Marketing and Recruitment)* *"On their website, they do not talk much about different activities and associations... When I visited, I found much more that was not available on JIBS' website."(S13) (Marketing and Recuritment)*
Theme 3	

Alignment and Authenticity in Branding	*"The international environment shown online is quite accurate." (S14) (Branding Alignment)* *"The group work and practical projects definitely match what they present digitally." (S6) (Branding Alignment)* *"The diversity is real …. You notice it straight away when you come here" (S12) (Branding Alignment)* *"The international aspect we highlight is true; you interact with people from different countries all the time" (E3)* *"When we students talk about our experiences, that has a real impact on how others view the university." (S7) (Stakeholders Influence)* *"People trust what we students say about the university because we actually studying here, so our experience matters" (S13) (Stakeholder Influence)* *"There is a strategy behind it, but not everyone in the organisation is involved in it." (E3) (Strategic Awareness)*

5. Discussion

This chapter discusses the empirical findings in relation to Sensemaking Theory and the existing literature on digital branding in higher education. It is structured around the three main themes that emerged from the analysis: Institutional Image in Digital Branding, and Alignment and Authenticity in Branding, and Digital Communication Practices.

5.1. Institutional Image in Digital Branding

Participants consistently associated the university's digital branding with professionalism, employability, institutional credibility, and internationalization, which was one of the most apparent patterns that emerged from the analysis. In the interviews, students frequently perceived the university's digital image as a representation of future opportunities and global career potential, while employees more frequently associated branding with institutional positioning and organizational legitimacy.

This finding is consistent with previous research that suggests universities are increasingly functioning as globally competitive brands rather than merely educational institutions (Hemsley-Brown et al., 2016; Brown & Carasso, 2013; Yaping et al., 2023).The students in the current study, similar to Li et al. (2025), predominantly utilized digital platforms to form their assessments of the university's credibility and appeal. Nevertheless, the results also contribute to the existing body of research by demonstrating that stakeholders did not passively consume digital branding messages; rather, they actively assessed whether these representations were plausible, recognizable, and consistent with their own expectations and experiences.

An ongoing trend in the interviews was that students perceived branding aspirational rather than literally. Even though the university's digital communication presented an "idealized" version of university life, several participants acknowledged this, but they did not necessarily perceive it negatively. Earlier discussions regarding authenticity in higher education branding are complicated by the study's findings. In previous literature, authenticity has been frequently defined as a direct alignment between organizational reality and branding claims (Girardin et al., 2023; Morhart et al., 2015). However, the current results indicate that a more nuanced interpretation is required. It appeared that students were receptive to a certain level of idealization, provided that the branding was emotionally recognizable and plausible.

Students appeared to be amenable to adopting a certain level of idealization if the branding was emotionally recognizable and plausible.

This reflects Weick's (1995) concept of plausibility when viewed through the lens of Sensemaking Theory. Stakeholders did not necessarily pursue complete veracity; rather, they developed "good enough" interpretations that facilitated their comprehension of the institution and its identity. Therefore, institutional credibility appeared to be less reliant on complete realism and more reliant on whether branding appeared to be attainable and credible over time.

The results also indicate that the institutional image was established by utilizing extracted cues. Students frequently alluded to rankings, international student representation, campus visuals, exchange opportunities, and professional website design when describing how they formulated their opinions of the university. This is consistent with Weick's (1995) assertion that stakeholders depend on specific signals when formulating more comprehensive organizational meanings. Likewise, Starbuck and Milliken (1988) argue that organizational members interpret environments through selective attention processes, in which apparently insignificant details become symbolically significant.

5.1.1. Cues and Institutional Image

International students, diversity representation, exchange opportunities, modern campus visuals, and professional layouts functioned as central interpretive anchors that enabled students to form more comprehensive assumptions about institutional quality and future opportunities.

This is consistent with prior research that contends that students' perceptions of institutional reputation and attractiveness are substantially influenced by digital branding (Nofrizal et al., 2024; Khoshtaria et al., 2020). By demonstrating how stakeholders actively translated specific digital symbols into broader identity narratives, the results expand this literature.

From the perspective of sensemaking, stakeholders extracted cues that aligned with their personal identities and aspirations. It appeared that student’s participants associated digital representations of diversity and mobility with future employability and professional legitimacy. This is characteristic of the identity construction dimension of Sensemaking Theory, in which individuals assess organizational communication through the lens of their own desired identities (Ashforth et al., 2008; Weick, 1995).

Furthermore, the results indicate that the institutional image was perceived differently by various stakeholder groups. In contrast to students, who primarily associated branding with prospective personal outcomes, employees assessed branding more strategically in terms of institutional consistency and organizational credibility.

This partially corroborates the earlier internal branding literature, which posits that employees and students occupy distinct interpretive positions within organizational branding processes (Iglesias et al., 2020; Punjaisri & Wilson, 2011). Conversely, the results indicate that these disparities are exacerbated within higher education institutions since universities serve as educational, professional, and social environments simultaneously.

5.1.2. Expectations and Retrospective Interpretation

Another critical observation pertains to the retrospective assessment of digital branding by students after their enrolment. Several participants disclosed that their perceptions of branding were altered because of their direct experience with university life.

When students contrasted their online expectations with their actual academic experiences, retrospective interpretation was particularly evident. This is strongly indicative of Weick's (1995) retrospective dimension of sensemaking, in which meaning is derived after experiences have occurred, rather than during the initial exposure.

Therefore, the results support prior research that posits that brand perception is formed through lived experiences rather than solely through marketing communication (Chen, 2022; Henderson et al., 2017). Nevertheless, the results also suggest that institutional credibility was not necessarily harmed by expectation disparities. In contrast, students frequently acknowledged a degree of discrepancy between branding and reality, as they perceived digital branding as inherently selective.

This partially challenges the literature that emphasizes authenticity as a strict consistency between institutional claims and experience (Girardin et al., 2023). Rather, the results indicate that authenticity in higher education branding may be more adaptable, with stakeholders being willing to accept idealization as long as the broader institutional narrative remains recognizable.

This pattern was further substantiated by the digital content analysis. Humour, friendships, social life, and emotional relatability were emphasized in Instagram and TikTok communication, while academic complexity and program demands were significantly less visible. Consequently, branding communication prioritized social belonging over academic challenge.

This generates a significant contradiction: students form their pre-enrolment their expectations about academic life primarily through content that deemphasizes academic rigor. While universities strive to appear emotionally engaging and attractive online, this communication

style may simultaneously cultivate unrealistic expectations about workload, assessment demands, and intellectual challenge. Therefore, the results suggest a fundamental tension between realistic representation and promotional communication in digital higher education branding.

5.2. Alignment and Authenticity in Branding

Participants consistently assessed whether the university's online image matched their everyday experiences. Students and employees actively contrasted online communication with what they experienced in real life, as opposed to passively absorbing branding messages. This supports previous research suggesting that perceived consistency between lived experience and institutional communication determines authenticity in higher education branding (Girardin et al., 2023; Chen, 2022).

The results indicate that, in general, participants thought the university's branding was credible and expertly portrayed, especially with relation to internationalization, employability, and student life. Participants did acknowledge, though, that digital branding frequently offered an unrealistic view of university life. Mampaey et al. (2019) have made similar discoveries and contend that universities often strike a compromise between institutional authenticity and promotional communication.

From the standpoint of sensemaking, this is consistent with Weick's (1995) notion of plausibility. Participants did not always anticipate that digital branding would accurately reflect reality. Rather, they assessed how recognized and sensible the branding felt considering their experiences. Participants typically maintained a favourable opinion of the university if the perceived gap between communication and reality was not too great.

How participants perceived the university through regular digital contacts outside of social media is another significant finding. In addition to standard digital systems like Canvas, Outlook communication, and internal university platforms, students and employees also mentioned Instagram, TikTok, and LinkedIn. In day-to-day academic life, these systems influenced opinions about professionalism, organization, and institutional credibility. This supports the claims made by Henderson et al. (2017) and Chen (2022) that ordinary digital experiences and institutional interactions, in addition to commercial communication, shape digital branding.

The results also showed some conflicts between the participants' experiences and the university's perceived image. Some students believed that regular communication techniques

did not always accurately reflect the university's international reputation. This was especially apparent when, despite the university's global positioning, portions of the communication continued to be heavily Swedish-oriented. These results support previous research that suggests perceptions of authenticity and trust may be weakened by discrepancies between branding promises and organizational behaviors (Waeraas & Solbakk, 2009; Girardin et al., 2023).

Therefore, the results show that authenticity in higher education branding is assessed by whether stakeholders can identify their experiences in the university's digital representations rather than by total correctness. When participants believed that the institution's communication reflected actual university reality rather than just advertising objectives, branding was perceived as being at its most authentic.

5.2.1. Symbolic vs Experiential Misalignment

The results indicated that participants were able to differentiate between various types of misalignments between branding and reality. Some inconsistencies were perceived as operational or manageable, while others were perceived as symbolically problematic due to their direct contradiction with the university's communicated identity.

The findings are noteworthy in terms of the use of language across digital platforms. The consistency between JU's international branding and the substantial presence of Swedish-language communication on TikTok was a topic of concern for a few international students.

This discovery is especially significant because it illustrates the symbolic significance of relatively insignificant communication practices within stakeholder sensemaking processes. Language served as an extracted cue that students used to assess whether the institution accurately represented its international identity claims, as viewed through the lens of Sensemaking Theory.

The results therefore indicate that international branding is not solely assessed through official statements regarding global engagement or diversity, but also through everyday communication practices that either include or exclude stakeholders in terms of their social and cultural backgrounds. Although the university vigorously promoted an international image through its website and LinkedIn communication, certain students perceived certain aspects of the social media communication as more locally focused and less accessible to non-Swedish audiences.

This partially contradicts the earlier branding literature, which has primarily concentrated on institutional reputation and communication strategy at a broader level (Melewar & Skinner, 2020; Hemsley-Brown et al., 2016). In contrast, the current findings suggest that stakeholders also assess authenticity by considering minor symbolic details, such as language accessibility, humour, and platform culture.

The students' interpretations of various forms of inconsistency were particularly revealing of the distinction between symbolic and experiential misalignment. Academic tensions or administrative challenges were frequently perceived as regular aspects of university life. However, symbolic inconsistencies, such as the combination of inaccessible language practices and international branding, were more detrimental because they directly challenged institutional identity claims.

This observation was significantly substantiated by the digital content analysis. Although LinkedIn communication consistently portrayed JIBS as professionally international and globally connected, Instagram and TikTok mainly interactions frequently drew on Swedish humour, and culturally localized references. Even though this bolstered the affective connection among local students, it also posed a risk of excluding certain international audiences.

This discovery enhances the existing body of literature by demonstrating that authenticity gaps may arise not only because of significant organizational contradictions, but also because of platform-specific communication practices that unintentionally indicate inclusion or exclusion. This is why authenticity was associated with not only the content that universities communicated, but also the individuals who were included in that communication.

5.2.2. Stakeholder Influence and Brand Co-Creation

The results also indicate that digital branding within higher education institutions is being co-created through stakeholder interaction, rather than being entirely controlled by the institution. Throughout the interviews, both students and employees acknowledged that the university's perception was significantly influenced by peer communication, student interaction, and online participation.

This is consistent with prior research that contends that brand meaning in digital environments is collaboratively negotiated rather than institutionally imposed (Dean et al., 2016; Foroudi et al., 2020). Nevertheless, the current research contributes to this body of work by demonstrating

that this co-creation is facilitated by ordinary social interaction, rather than solely through formal branding participation.

Students frequently underscored that collegial communication appeared to be more reliable than official institutional messaging. Similarly, employees acknowledged the increasing impact of communication generated by stakeholders. Therefore, the results indicate that institutional branding is becoming a decentralized social process in which the meaning is constantly transformed through interaction, humour, sharing practices, recommendations, and online discussion.

This process was especially evident during the digital content analysis. Institutional posts were frequently transformed into collective student conversations in the comment sections of Instagram and TikTok, where users responded emotionally, shared jokes, tagged peers, and connected posts to their own experiences. Particularly robust engagement was frequently observed in content concerning grades, deadlines, tension, and routines.

This is indicative of the fundamentally social nature of interpretation from a sensemaking perspective (Weick, 1995). Stakeholders did not establish meaning independently; rather, they did so collectively by engaging with digital communities and their peers. Consequently, institutional posts were less of a conduit for predetermined messages and more of a social environment in which students collaborated to establish mutual interpretations of university life.

In addition, the results indicate a contradiction within stakeholder co-creation. The institutional control over branding narratives was reduced because of student participation, which simultaneously enhanced perceptions of relatability and authenticity. However, universities were unable to completely predict how institutional meaning would be interpreted, reshaped, or circulated online, even though they could encourage interaction.

This partially challenges the previous internal branding literature, which frequently implies that organizations can strategically align stakeholder behaviour with institutional identity (Punjaisri & Wilson, 2011; Iglesias et al., 2020). In contrast, the findings indicate that digital branding in higher education environments is partially unpredictable due to the active reinterpretation and personalization of institutional communication by stakeholders based on their own experiences and social relationships. Having established how stakeholders co-create brand meaning, we now examine the specific communication practices, platform choice, content style, and channel segmentation, through which this co-creation unfolds.

5.3. Digital Communication Practices

The communication practices employed across various digital platforms significantly influence the digital branding of higher education institutions as indicated in the findings. Instead of functioning as a single, unified branding system, JU's/JIBS digital communication appeared fragmented across channels, audiences, and communication styles.

This aligns with prior research that indicates universities are progressively shifting their communication strategies across digital platforms to accommodate their target audiences (Demirer, 2025; Peruta & Shields, 2017). In addition, the results suggest that this segmentation generates numerous parallel institutional identities rather than a single cohesive brand narrative.

This finding adds to the existing digital branding literature by illustrating how stakeholders actively categorize and interpret platforms symbolically. The platforms were not merely perceived as communication tools; rather, they were interpreted as symbols of various institutional identities.

The fragmented communication structure in question is significant of the co-created digital branding environments that Foroudi et al. (2020) refer to. In these environments, institutional identity is perpetually shaped by the interaction between organizations and stakeholders. The current research, however, indicates that platform segmentation may also result in internal inconsistencies in the way the institution is perceived by different audiences.

From a sensemaking perspective, stakeholders interpreted branding differently based on the platform-specific cues they encountered. Instagram and TikTok were the primary sources of emotional and social signals that students extracted, while LinkedIn communication facilitated interpretations related to professionalism and employability. This illustrates the pattern of digital branding becoming context-dependent, with the meaning of the brand evolving in accordance with the platform culture and audience expectations.

5.3.1. Planned vs Emergent Branding

The relationship between planned institutional branding and organically emergent communication practices was one of the most apparent tensions that emerged from the findings. Employees characterized branding as both strategically managed and a natural process that emerges from daily activities, student interaction, faculty communication, and decentralized content creation.

A significant tension that emerged from the interviews was that not all employees had the same understanding of the university's branding strategy. Some participants defined branding as meticulously planned and strategically coordinated, while others perceived digital branding as relatively fragmented or loosely organized.

These results support the literature that has previously distinguished between emergent and planned branding processes (Vallaster & de Chernatony, 2006; Ind & Bjerk, 2007). Conversely, the results indicate that branding may never be entirely centralized in higher education institutions as a result of decentralized communication structures, academic autonomy, and organizational complexity.

This fragmentation was further substantiated by the digital content analysis. Platforms and organizational actors exhibited substantial variation in communication styles. Other content was heavily influenced by student interaction or appeared spontaneously, while some content strongly reflected institutional professionalism and strategic positioning.

This partially challenges previous branding models that presume organizations can sustain relatively coherent brand identities through strategic communication management (Melewar & Skinner, 2020). On the contrary, the results indicate that the process of digital branding within universities is a perpetual negotiation between institutional intentions and stakeholder participation.

This fragmentation is comprehensible when viewed through the lens of Sensemaking Theory, as stakeholders interpret communication from a local and social perspective, rather than from a centralized organizational perspective. Consequently, the communication practices that employees and students encountered most directly within their own environments and experiences were the basis for their understanding of branding.

5.3.2. Expertise Tension and Strategy Confusion

An interesting finding from the research was that employees demonstrated varying levels of understanding regarding digital branding. Some participants highlighted the significance of branding for exposure, recruitment, and competitiveness, while others were more critical of branding strategies. These differences were often linked to the employees' professional responsibilities and educational backgrounds.

Another issue identified by the research was uncertainty about who is truly responsible for representing the university online. Some employees believed that all staff members contribute

to the university's image through their everyday interactions with students and their online presence, while others contended that the communication department holds primary responsibility for branding.

This finding partially contradicts the existing literature on internal branding, which frequently suggests that employees with a better understanding of branding are more likely to support it (Piehler et al., 2016; King & Grace, 2008). In this study, employees with greater academic or professional expertise sometimes appeared more sceptical of branding activities rather than more supportive. Academic staff often prioritized educational quality and institutional legitimacy over visibility or engagement.

However, this observation arose from a limited number of participants and should be interpreted with caution. The results suggest a tentative tension regarding expertise rather than a fully established expertise paradox, where professional or academic expertise does not necessarily lead to increased support for branding activities. Since this pattern emerged from a limited subset of participants, further research is needed to determine whether this tension exists in higher education institutions on a broader scale.

From a sensemaking perspective, this illustrates the processes involved in identity creation (Weick, 1995). Employees understood branding through their experiences at the university and their professional identities. Additionally, the findings indicated that employees' awareness of the branding strategy varied, leading to a fragmented understanding of branding within the organization. This supports earlier studies that show how universities' decentralized systems and strong professional autonomy complicate the development of internal branding alignment (Waeraas & Solbakk, 2009; Mampaey et al., 2019).

5.3.3. Student-Driven Branding

Student participants consistently described peer communication as more authentic and trustworthy. Rather than interpreting branding solely through institutional messaging, students often relied on their peers' experiences, interactions, and online behavior. This aligns with previous research indicating that digital branding in higher education has increasingly become co-created through stakeholder participation (Foroudi et al., 2020; Girardin et al., 2023). Moreover, the findings suggest that peer communication is perceived as more relatable, experience-based, and socially credible compared to institutional communication.

The digital content analysis reinforced this trend. Student ambassadors and peer-generated content frequently depicted everyday student experiences, such as stress, finances, friendships, deadlines, and campus life. Instead of showcasing highly polished representations, student ambassadors were portrayed as relatable individuals navigating familiar university situations.

These forms of communication generated significant engagement. Students often shared experiences, tagged peers, used humour, and collectively interpreted university life through comment sections and digital interactions. Posts related to exams, grades, and student stress received particularly high engagement, indicating that emotional familiarity plays a crucial role in student-driven branding.

From a sensemaking perspective, this reflects the social and ongoing nature of meaning construction (Weick, 1995). Students actively constructed brand meaning through peer interactions, shared interpretations, humour, and participation within digital communities.

The findings also invite a more nuanced understanding of authenticity in digital higher education branding. While students emphasized their preference for "realistic" and "authentic" communication, highly engaging content often included humour, emotional expression, or selective presentation.

However, this should not be seen as a contradiction between curated institutional communication and authentic peer communication, as peer-generated content is itself selectively constructed and curated. Instead, the findings highlight a tension between different forms of curation and their perceived authenticity. Students in this study engaged more strongly with peer-curated content, which they considered more relatable, grounded in experience, and socially credible compared to institutional messaging.

Therefore, authenticity in digital higher education branding appears to depend less on the absence of curation and more on how different forms of curation are interpreted through emotional familiarity, social credibility, and lived experiences. Humor, peer interaction, and everyday experiences contributed to perceptions of authenticity, even when content remained selective or idealized.

These findings suggest that universities do not necessarily need to abandon curated branding practices. Instead, institutions may benefit from incorporating emotionally relatable and

experience-based communication that aligns more closely with students lived experiences and social interpretations.

5.4. Strategic Awareness and Internal Branding

The results indicate that stakeholder groups exhibited a significant variation in strategic awareness of digital branding. Academic staff frequently characterized branding as more peripheral to their professional responsibilities, whereas employees who were more directly involved in communication or recruitment activities generally exhibited a greater consciousness of institutional messaging strategies and branding objectives. This corresponds with prior internal branding literature suggesting that employee engagement and organizational identification influence the internal interpretation and implementation of branding (Punjaisri & Wilson, 2011; Sheikh et al., 2024). Nevertheless, the results also indicate that universities encounter additional obstacles since institutional branding is conducted in highly decentralized professional environments, where employees have varying levels of communication involvement, identities, and priorities.

The findings therefore indicate that the distribution of internal branding within higher education institutions may continue to be uneven across organizational functions. The interpretation of branding by communication professionals was generally strategic, while academic employees frequently approached branding indirectly through teaching, research, and student interaction, rather than through formal communication strategy.

Whisman (2009) argues that internal branding research has overemphasized the complexity of corporate environments while underestimating the complexity of universities as decentralized professional organizations. This partially supports his argument. Universities differ from conventional corporations in that they may have multiple professional subcultures that interpret institutional priorities differently.

From a Sensemaking Theory perspective, this fragmentation is understandable, as stakeholders interpreted branding through localized experiences and professional identities, rather than through a single shared organizational understanding. Consequently, meaning emerges through social and contextual factors rather than through direct institutional transmission.

Internal branding cannot be exclusively dependent on communication departments or strategic campaigns, which is a significant consequence of these discoveries. Institutional identity

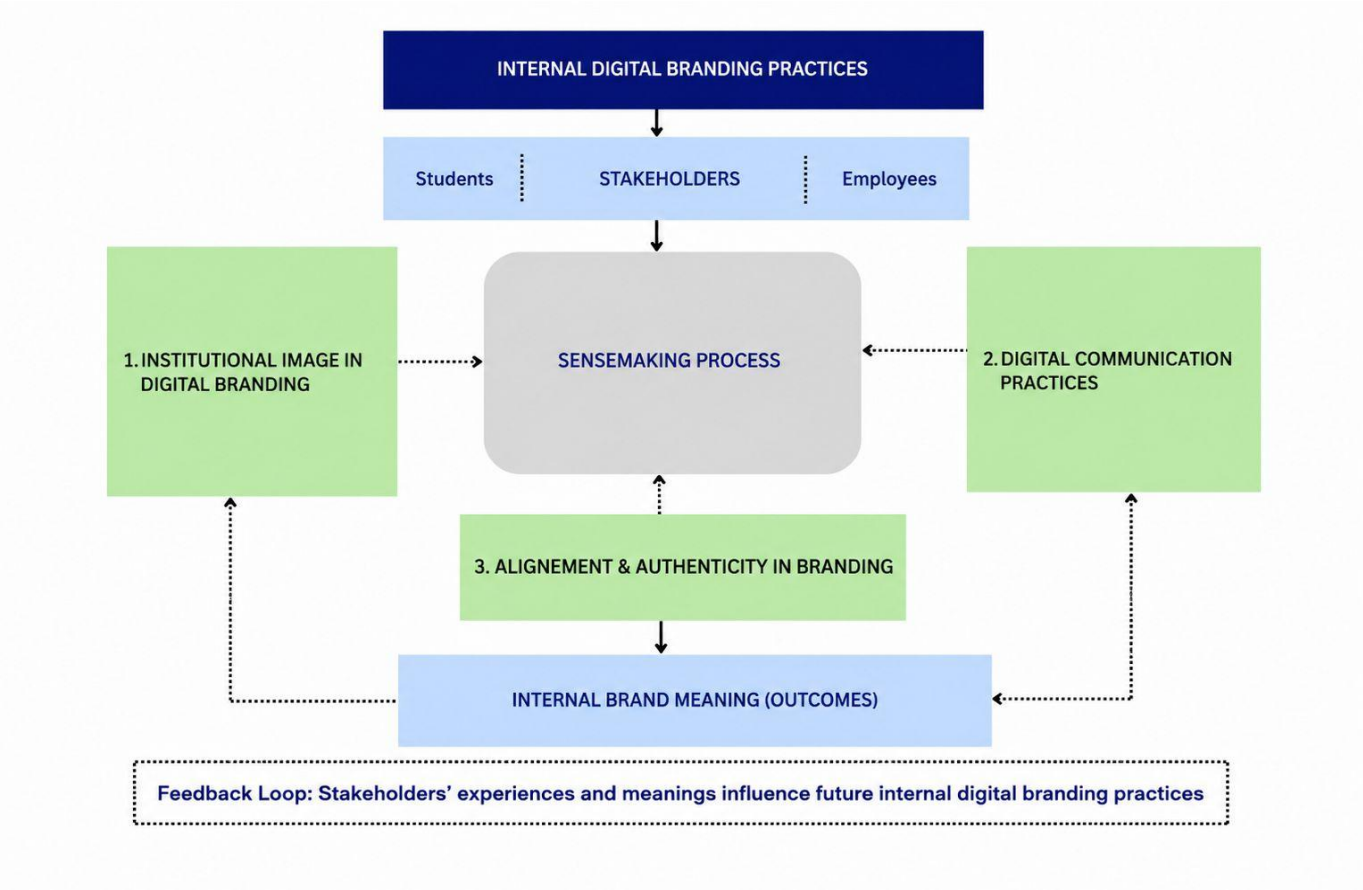
becomes dependent on broader organizational alignment among communication, student experience, teaching practices, and institutional culture, as stakeholders continuously interpret, reshape, and negotiate branding through daily interaction.

Thus, the results contribute to the existing literature by illustrating that internal digital branding within higher education institutions is not merely a matter of strategic communication management. Rather, it indicates an ongoing organizational sensemaking process that is simultaneously influenced by platform cultures, stakeholder participation, emotional interaction, institutional practices, and ordinary lived experience.

5.5. A Sensemaking Model of Internal Digital Branding in Higher Education

Based on the empirical findings and theoretical integration presented in this chapter, Figure 5 presents a conceptual model of internal digital branding sensemaking in higher education. Before examining the figure, note three key components that emerged from our data: (1) institutional image in digital branding, (2) digital communication practices, and (3) alignment and authenticity in branding. These dimensions do not operate sequentially but interact continuously as stakeholders interpret branding through identity, social interaction, and prior experiences (Weick, 1995).

Figure 4: A Sensemaking Model of Internal Digital Branding in Higher Education



Returning to the model's structure, the figure visualizes how institutional branding messages enter stakeholder awareness through digital communication channels and institutional image cues. These inputs are filtered through sensemaking processes – retrospection, extracted cues, plausibility, and social interaction – which generate internal brand meanings such as trust, engagement, and identification. Critically, the feedback loop (bottom of the figure) captures the recursive nature of this process: stakeholders' interpretations continuously influence future branding practices and communication. This dynamic highlight that internal stakeholders are not merely recipients of brand messages but active co-creators of brand meaning (Iglesias et al., 2020; Dean et al., 2016).

6. Conclusion

This chapter concludes the thesis by summarizing the main findings and their theoretical and practical contributions. It also acknowledges the limitations of the study and proposes directions for future research on internal digital branding in higher education.

This study aimed to investigate how employees and students make sense of internal digital branding practices within higher education institutions. Utilizing Sensemaking Theory (Weick, 1995; Maitlis & Christianson, 2014) and a qualitative single-case study design at Jönköping International Business School, the research explored how stakeholders interpret and evaluate institutional digital branding in daily university contexts. The findings indicate that sensemaking in digital branding is not a linear, one-way process but rather a complex, ongoing, and socially negotiated activity characterized by strategic fragmentation, varying levels of awareness, and the coexistence of multiple interpretations among stakeholder groups. Three main themes emerged from the analysis: Institutional Image in Digital Branding, Digital Communication Practices, and Alignment and Authenticity in Branding. Through these themes, the study identified two novel concepts the expertise tension and the authenticity tenstion that expand the existing theoretical understanding. The following sections will discuss the theoretical contributions, practical implications, strengths and limitations, and future research directions stemming from this study.

6.1. Theoretical Contributions

This study makes three primary theoretical contributions. First, it expands the literature on higher education branding by shifting the focus from external outcomes to internal interpretive processes (Hemsley-Brown et al., 2016; Waeraas & Solbakk, 2009). While previous research has concentrated on how branding influences student recruitment and institutional reputation, this study investigates how students and employees interpret digital branding in their daily organizational lives. This transition from outcomes to processes addresses a significant gap in the literature.

Second, the study applies Sensemaking Theory (Weick, 1995; Maitlis & Christianson, 2014) to the context of digital branding in higher education, demonstrating the utility of this framework for understanding how stakeholders actively construct brand meaning. The findings indicate that the seven properties of sensemaking identity, retrospection, enactment, social

nature, ongoing process, extracted cues, and plausibility are all pertinent to understanding stakeholder interpretations of digital branding.

Third, the study introduces two novel concepts: the expertise tension and the authenticity tension, which enhance the existing understanding of internal branding and digital communication. The expertise tension highlights how professional expertise can create critical distance and scepticism rather than alignment, challenging assumptions within the internal branding literature. The authenticity tension reveals that stakeholders simultaneously demand authenticity while engaging most enthusiastically with curated content, suggesting that a more nuanced understanding of authenticity in digital branding is necessary.

6.2. Practical Implications

The study also provides five practical insights for university administrators and communication professionals. First, the findings suggest that universities should invest in internal branding that makes employees aware of digital branding strategies and involves them in their execution. For JIBS specifically, this means implementing two concrete initiatives; (a) a biannual internal branding workshop for all academic and administrative staff, where digital branding strategy is explained and staff are invited to provide input, and (b) integrating brand communication KPIs into programme coordinators' performance reviews, such as sharing one research highlight on LinkedIn per semester or contributing one student-facing post for Instagram. As indicated by the findings, when employees are unaware of the strategy or perceive branding as solely the responsibility of the communications department, opportunities for brand alignment are lost.

Second, the distinction between symbolic and experiential misalignment suggests that universities should prioritize addressing symbolic contradictions visible, tangible evidence that contradicts core brand claims as these may be more damaging than operational delays. For JIBS, addressing the presence of Swedish-language signage on an international campus represents a relatively low-cost intervention with high symbolic value.

Third, the expertise tension suggests that universities cannot assume that faculty with digital expertise will automatically serve as brand ambassadors. Instead, universities should engage with faculty critiques of digital communication, respecting professional autonomy while identifying areas of alignment where faculty can contribute authentically.

Fourth, the authenticity tension suggests that JIBS should adopt a segmented authenticity strategy: the communications team should maintain polished, curated content on LinkedIn and the official website for recruitment purposes, while simultaneously encouraging and amplifying student-generated content on Instagram and TikTok through reposts, student ambassador programmes, and featured 'takeover' days. This dual approach acknowledges that prospective students expect professionalism from official channels but authenticity from peer content.

Finally, the resilience demonstrated by JIBS students despite misalignments suggests that the university need not achieve perfect alignment between digital branding and lived experience. Provided that core identity claims, internationalization, career focus, academic credibility remain credible, and discrepancies are not perceived as intentional deception, students will maintain favourable perceptions. For JIBS, this means focusing corrective efforts on symbolic contradictions (e.g., Swedish-language dominance on TikTok) rather than operational frustrations (e.g., course scheduling delays), which students already expect as normal university experiences.

6.3. Limitations

This study has several limitations that should be acknowledged when interpreting its findings.

Firstly, the single-case study design restricts the transferability of the findings. The research focused exclusively on Jönköping International Business School, a highly internationalized, research-oriented institution with private foundation status. While this design allowed for an in-depth, contextual exploration of sensemaking processes, the results may not be directly applicable to other institutional contexts, such as public universities, teaching-focused institutions, or universities in different national settings. Varying organizational cultures, resources, and stakeholder compositions may exhibit different patterns of sensemaking.

Secondly, the reliance on retrospective interview data means that the study could not capture sensemaking as it unfolds in real time. Interviews depend on participants' recollections of their experiences, which may be influenced by subsequent events or imperfect memory. The dynamic, emergent nature of sensemaking may not be fully captured through retrospective accounts alone. Future research employing digital ethnography or longitudinal methods could complement these findings by observing sensemaking as it occurs.

Thirdly, the insider researcher position may have introduced biases during data collection and interpretation. Both researchers were students at JIBS, which could lead to over-familiarity with the setting, assumptions about shared understanding, or reluctance to critique the institution. Although the study employed explicit reflexivity, peer debriefing with the supervisor and external colleagues, and transparent reporting through direct participant quotes, complete objectivity is neither possible nor desirable in interpretivist research. Therefore, the findings should be understood as co-constructed interpretations rather than objective truths.

Fourthly, the small sample size of employees limits the generalizability of the employee-related findings. The sample included only four employees, with limited representation from various academic disciplines and seniority levels. Therefore, the tentative expertise tension identified in the study arose from a limited subset of participants and should be interpreted cautiously. Further research with larger and more diverse employee samples is needed to determine whether this pattern exists on a broader scale.

Lastly, the cross-sectional nature of data collection provides only a snapshot of sensemaking at a single point in time. The study captured sensemaking during a period when the university was undergoing digital transformation, including the development of a new website. However, sensemaking is an ongoing process (Weick, 1995), and the findings represent only a snapshot of interpretations at a particular moment. Without longitudinal data, it is challenging to assess how sensemaking evolves in response to organizational changes, leadership shifts, or accumulated experiences over time.

6.4. Future Research Areas

Based on the limitations identified in the previous section and the novel findings of this study, several directions for future research are suggested.

This study focused exclusively on Jönköping International Business School, which limits the transferability of its findings. To overcome this limitation, future research should investigate whether similar patterns of sensemaking occur in other higher education contexts. Comparative studies could explore how sensemaking varies between public and private universities, research-intensive and teaching-focused institutions, and universities across different national and cultural settings. Such comparisons would help identify contextual factors, such as organizational culture, resource availability, and leadership commitment to branding, that influence how internal stakeholders interpret digital branding.

The reliance on retrospective interviews meant that this study could not capture sensemaking as it unfolds in real time. To address this limitation, future research should employ longitudinal designs. Researchers could track how student interpretations of digital branding evolve throughout their academic journey, from initial discovery to graduation and alumni status. Similarly, longitudinal studies could examine how employee sensemaking changes in response to organizational events, leadership transitions, or shifts in branding strategy. Methods such as repeated interviews, diary methods, or digital ethnography would enable the capture of sensemaking as it occurs rather than retrospectively.

The small employee sample (four participants) restricts the generalizability of the findings related to employees, particularly the tentative expertise tension identified from this limited subset. To address this limitation, future research should investigate whether similar tensions arise in other professional domains with larger and more diverse samples. Specifically, researchers should explore whether professionals in law, medicine, engineering, or information technology exhibit similar scepticism toward organizational branding efforts. Understanding how organizations can effectively engage critical professionals in brand co-creation without necessitating uncritical participation remains an important practical and theoretical question.

This study concentrated solely on internal stakeholders and did not examine external stakeholders' interpretations of digital branding. To address this limitation, future research should expand the focus to include prospective students, parents, employers, and alumni. Comparative studies could investigate how sensemaking processes differ between internal and external stakeholders and how these distinct interpretive communities interact to shape overall institutional reputation.

The identification of the expertise tension where marketing faculty with professional expertise in digital communication intentionally disengage from institutional branding due to a critical awareness of social media's harms calls for further investigation. Future research should explore whether similar tensions or paradoxes arise in other professional domains, such as law, medicine, engineering, or information technology, where professional expertise may create distance or scepticism towards organizational branding efforts. Understanding how organizations can effectively engage critical professionals in brand co-creation without requiring uncritical participation is an important practical and theoretical question.

The cross-sectional nature of this study provides only a snapshot of sensemaking at a single point in time. To address this limitation, future research should utilize longitudinal designs to

explore how sensemaking evolves in response to organizational changes, leadership shifts, or accumulated experiences over time. Such research would complement the current findings by capturing the dynamic, ongoing nature of sensemaking that Weick (1995) emphasizes.

7. References

Alvesson, M., & Sköldberg, K. (2017). *Reflexive methodology: New vistas for qualitative research* (3rd ed.). SAGE Publications. Sage Research Methods - Reflexive Methodology: New Vistas for Qualitative Research

Ashforth, B. E., Harrison, S. H., & Corley, K. G. (2008). Identification in organizations: An examination of four fundamental questions. *Journal of Management, 34*(3), 325–374. (PDF) Identification in Organizations: An Examination of Four Fundamental Questions

Baltar, F., & Brunet, I. (2012). Social research 2.0: virtual snowball sampling method using Facebook. *Internet Research*, *22*(1), 57–74. https://doi.org/10.1108/10662241211199960

Barros, F. R. de, Oliveira, J. V. F. de, Muglia, T. B., & Lima, H. da C. G. (2025). Institutional communication strategies in higher education institutions: A systematic literature review. *Educationis*, *12*(2). https://doi.org/10.6008/CBPC2318-3047.2024.002.0007

Brakus, J. J., Schmitt, B. H., & Zarantonello, L. (2009). Brand Experience: What is It? How is it Measured? Does it Affect Loyalty? *Journal of Marketing*, *73*(3), 52–68. https://doi.org/10.1509/jmkg.73.3.052

Berger, R. (2015). Now I see it, now I don't: researcher's position and reflexivity in qualitative research. *Qualitative Research*: QR, *15*(2), 219–234. https://doi.org/10.1177/1468794112468475

Bell, E., & Bryman, A. (2006). The Ethics of Management Research: An Exploratory Content analysis. *British Journal of Management*, *18*(1), 63–77. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-8551.2006.00487.x

Bell, E., Bryman, A., & Harley, B. (2019). *Business Research Methods*, 5th edn, Oxford: Oxford University Press

Boswell, E., & Babchuk, W. A. (2022). Philosophical and theoretical underpinnings of qualitative research. In Elsevier eBooks (pp. 1–13). https://doi.org/10.1016/b978-0-12-818630-5.11001-2

Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2006). Using thematic analysis in psychology. Qualitative Research in Psychology, 3(2), 77–101. https://doi.org/10.1191/1478088706qp063oa

Brown, A. D., Colville, I., & Pye, A. (2015). Making sense of sensemaking in organization studies. *Organization Studies, 36*(2), 265–277. (PDF) Making Sense of Sensemaking in Organization Studies

Brown, R., & Carasso, H. (2013). *Everything for sale? The marketisation of UK higher education*. Routledge. (PDF) Everything for sale? The marketisation of UK higher education

Brunsson, N. (1982). The irrationality of action and action rationality: Decisions, ideologies and organizational actions. *Journal of Management Studies, 19*(1), 29–44. THE IRRATIONALITY OF ACTION AND ACTION RATIONALITY: DECISIONS, IDEOLOGIES AND ORGANIZATIONAL ACTIONS - Brunsson - 1982 - Journal of Management Studies - Wiley Online Library

Burmann, C., & Zeplin, S. (2005). Building brand commitment: A behavioural approach to internal brand management. *Journal of Brand Management*, *12*(4), 279–300. https://doi.org/10.1057/palgrave.bm.2540223

Buyanza-Mwidima, C., & Nkeni, A. (2021). The Emerging Strategies for Higher Education Marketing in the 21st Century. *Higher Education Research*, *6*(5), 98. https://doi.org/10.11648/j.her.20210605.11

Chen, S. (2022). University branding: Student experience, value perception, and consumption journey. *Journal of Marketing for Higher Education*, *35*(2), 187–206. https://doi.org/10.1080/08841241.2022.2109092

Clark, P., Chapleo, C., & Suomi, K. (2019). "Branding higher education: an exploration of the role of internal branding on middle management in a university rebrand." *Tertiary Education and Management*, *26*(2), 131–149. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11233-019-09054-9

Constantinides, E., & Stagno, M. C. Z. (2011). Potential of the social media as instruments of higher education marketing: a segmentation study. *Journal of Marketing for HIGHER EDUCATION*, *21*(1), 7–24. https://doi.org/10.1080/08841241.2011.573593

Creswell, J. W. (2014). Research design: Qualitative, quantitative, and mixed methods approach (4th ed.). SAGE Publications.

Demirer, D. P. (2025). Optimizing social media engagement for university branding: A content strategy framework for higher education institutions. *European Journal of Social Sciences Education and Research*, *12*(2), 84–98. https://doi.org/10.26417/bgr7yv84

Dean, D., Arroyo-Gamez, R. E., Punjaisri, K., & Pich, C. (2016). Internal brand co-creation: The experiential brand meaning cycle in higher education. *Journal of Business Research, 69*(8), 3041–3048. Internal brand co-creation: The experiential brand meaning cycle in higher education - ScienceDirect

Drisko, J. W. (2024). Transferability and generalization in qualitative research. Research on Social Work Practice, 35(1), 102–110. https://doi.org/10.1177/10497315241256560 https://doi.org/10.1111/apps.12414

Easterby-Smith, M., Jaspersen, J. L. Thorpe, R., & Valizade, D. (2021). Management and Business Research (7th ed). Sage Publications

Edwards, M. R. (2005). Organizational identification: A conceptual and operational review. *International Journal of Management Reviews, 7*(4), 207–230. Organizational Identification: A Conceptual and Operational Review | Request PDF

Feldman, M. S., & Orlikowski, W. J. (2011). Theorizing practice and practicing theory. *Organization Science, 22*(5), 1240–1253. Theorizing practice and practicing theory.

Foroudi, P., Akarsu, T. N., Marvi, R., & Balakrishnan, J. (2020). Intellectual evolution of social media branding: A systematic literature review. *Journal of Business Research, 117*, 682–700. Intellectual evolution of social innovation: A bibliometric analysis and avenues for future research trends | Request PDF

Gapp, R., & Fisher, R. (2007). Developing an intrapreneur-led three-phase model of internal branding. *Journal of Brand Management, 14*(5), 396–409. (PDF) Developing an intrapreneur-led three-phase model of innovation

Gioia, D. A., Price, K. N., Hamilton, A. L., & Thomas, J. B. (2010). Forging an identity: An insider-outsider study of processes involved in the formation of organizational identity. *Administrative Science Quarterly, 55*(1), 1–46. Forging an Identity: An Insider-outsider Study of Processes Involved in the Formation of Organizational Identity | Request PDF

Girard, T., Pinar, M., & Lysiak, L. (2020). Understanding student perceptions of their personal branding in higher education. *Journal of Higher Education Theory and Practice*, *20*(13). https://doi.org/10.33423/jhetp.v20i13.3839

Girardin, F., Blal, I., & Lunardo, R. (2023). The role of brand authenticity for higher education institutions. *Journal of Marketing for Higher Education*, *34*(2), 1056–1076. https://doi.org/10.1080/08841241.2023.2172642

Guba, E. G. (1981). Criteria for assessing the trustworthiness of naturalistic inquiries. *ECTJ*, *29*(2). https://doi.org/10.1007/bf02766777

Gallup. (2025). U.S. public trust in higher ed rises from recent low. Gallup News. Retrieved from https://news.gallup.com/poll/692519/public-trust-higher-ed-rises.aspx

Hemsley-Brown, J., Melewar, T., Nguyen, B., & Wilson, E. J. (2016). "Exploring brand identity, meaning, image, and reputation (BIMIR) in higher education: A special section." *Journal of Business Research*, *69*(8), 3019–3022. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2016.01.016

Hemsley-Brown, J., & Oplatka, I. (2015). University choice: What do we know, what don't we know, and what do we still need to find out? *International Journal of Educational Management, 29*(3), 254–274 (PDF) University choice: what do we know, what don't we know and what do we still need to find out?

Henderson, M., Selwyn, N., & Aston, R. (2017). What works and why? Student perceptions of 'useful' digital technology in university teaching and learning. *Studies in Higher Education*, *42*(8), 1567–1579. https://doi.org/10.1080/03075079.2015.1007946

Holt, R., & Wiedner, R. (2024). Flipping sensemaking on its head: From common sense to sensus communis. *Organization Studies, 45*(9), 1253–1275. (PDF) Flipping Sensemaking on its Head: From common sense to sensus communis

Huber, S. G., & Helm, C. (2020). COVID-19 and schooling: Evaluation, assessment and accountability in times of crises. *Educational Assessment, Evaluation and Accountability, 32*(2), 237–270. (PDF) COVID-19 and schooling: evaluation, assessment and accountability in times of crises—reacting quickly to explore key issues for policy, practice and research with the school barometer

Ind, N., & Bjerk, R. (2007). The concept of participatory brand management. *Journal of Brand Management, 14*(5), 383–394. (PDF) The concept of participatory market orientation: An organisation-wide approach to enhancing brand equity

Judson, K. M., Aurand, T. W., Gorchels, L., & Gordon, G. L. (2008). Building a university brand from within: A comparison of coaches' perspectives of internal branding. *Journal of Marketing for Higher Education, 18*(1), 97–114. Building a University Brand from Within: A Comparison of Coaches' Perspectives of Internal Branding | Request PDF

Khoshtaria, T., Datuashvili, D., & Matin, A. (2020). "The impact of brand equity dimensions on university reputation: an empirical study of Georgian higher education." *Journal of Marketing for Higher Education*, *30*(2), 239–255. https://doi.org/10.1080/08841241.2020.1725955

Korstjens, I., & Moser, A. (2017). Series: Practical guidance to qualitative research. Part 4: Trustworthiness and publishing. European Journal of General Practice, 24(1), 120–124. https://doi.org/10.1080/13814788.2017.1375092

King, C., & Grace, D. (2008). Internal branding: Exploring the employee's perspective. *Journal of Brand Management, 15*(5), 358–372. (PDF) Internal branding: Exploring the employee's perspective

Laryeafio, M. N., & Ogbewe, O. C. (2023). Ethical consideration dilemma: systematic review of ethics in qualitative data collection through interviews. Journal of Ethics in Entrepreneurship and Technology, 3(2), 94–110. https://doi.org/10.1108/jeet-09-2022-0014

Li, S., Quan, Y., Xiao, L., Ren, H., & Abinova, A. Y. (2025). Exploring the influence of social media communication and brand image on international student enrollment intentions in higher education. *Frontiers in Education*, *10*. https://doi.org/10.3389/feduc.2025.1618524

Louis, M. R. (1980). Surprise and sense making: What newcomers experience in entering unfamiliar organizational settings. *Administrative Science Quarterly, 25*(2), 226–251. Surprise and sense making: what newcomers experience in entering unfamiliar organizational settings - PubMed

Maitlis, S., & Christianson, M. (2014). Sensemaking in organizations: Taking stock and moving forward. *Academy of Management Annals, 8*(1), 57–125. (PDF) Sensemaking in Organizations: Taking Stock and Moving Forward

Mampaey, J., Schtemberg, V., Schalk, J., & Huisman, J. (2019). How do organizational identity threats and identity work explain the emergence of brand asynchrony in higher education? *Journal of Management Studies, 56*(8), 1571–1596.

Marginson, S. (2018). Global trends in higher education financing: The United Kingdom. *International Journal of Educational Development*, *58*, 26–36. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijedudev.2017.03.008

Morhart, F. M., Herzog, W., & Tomczak, T. (2009). Brand-specific leadership: Turning employees into brand champions. *Journal of Marketing, 73*(5), 122–142. (PDF) Brand-Specific Leadership: Turning Employees into Brand Champions

Morhart, F., Malär, L., Guèvremont, A., Girardin, F., & Grohmann, B. (2015). Brand authenticity: An integrative framework and measurement scale. *Journal of Consumer Psychology*, *25*(2), 200–218. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jcps.2014.11.006

Naidoo, R., & Pringle, J. (2014). Students' sense of belonging and identity in higher education. *Studies in Higher Education, 39*(8), 1436–1450. (PDF) Students' sense of belonging in higher education: the impacts of social class, locality and institutional habitus

Nofrizal, Juju, U., & Aznuriyandi. (2024). Finding reasons to choose a campus: The impact of social media and brand strategy. *Higher Education Quarterly*, *78*(3), 988–1015. https://doi.org/10.1111/hequ.12495

Nowell, L. S., Norris, J. M., White, D. E., & Moules, N. J. (2017). Thematic analysis. *International Journal of Qualitative Methods*, *16*(1). https://doi.org/10.1177/1609406917733847

Orlikowski, W. J. (2000). Using technology and constituting structures: A practice lens for studying technology in organizations. *Organization Science, 11*(4), 404–428. Using Technology and Constituting Structures: A Practice Lens for Studying Technology in Organizations on JSTOR

Othman, A. K., Hamzah, M. I., & Abdullah, Z. (2025). Authenticity and trust in higher education digital branding: A qualitative inquiry. *Journal of Marketing for Higher Education, 35*(1), 88–105. arodes.hes-so.ch/record/12245/files/Girardin_2023_the_role_of_brand_authenticity.pdf

Pan, S. L., & Nishant, R. (2023). Artificial intelligence for digital sustainability: An insight into domain-specific research and future directions. *International Journal of Information Management*, *72*, Article 102668. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijinfomgt.2023.102668

Perera, C. H., Nayak, R., & Long, N. V. T. (2022). The impact of digital marketing on student enrollment in higher education: A systematic review. *Journal of Marketing for Higher Education, 32*(2), 189–208. The Impact of Digital Marketing on Student Enrollment in Higher Education: A Conceptual Model | Request PDFpi

Peruta, A., & Shields, A. B. (2017). Social media in higher education: understanding how colleges and universities use Facebook. *Journal of Marketing for HIGHER EDUCATION*, *27*(1), 131–143. https://doi.org/10.1080/08841241.2016.1212451

Pervin, N., & Mokhtar, M. (2022). The Interpretivist Research Paradigm: a subjective notion of a social context. International Journal of Academic Research in Progressive Education and Development, 11(2). https://doi.org/10.6007/ijarped/v11-i2/12938

Piehler, R., King, C., Burmann, C., & Xiong, L. (2016). The importance of employee brand understanding, brand identification, and brand commitment in realizing brand citizenship behaviour. *European Journal of Marketing, 50*(9/10), 1575–1601. The importance of employee brand understanding, brand identification, and brand commitment in realizing brand citizenship behaviour | Request PDF

Punjaisri, K., & Wilson, A. (2011). Internal branding process: key mechanisms, outcomes and moderating factors. *European Journal of Marketing*, *45*(9/10), 1521–1537. https://doi.org/10.1108/03090561111151871

Riketta, M. (2005). Organizational identification: A meta-analysis. *Journal of Vocational Behavior, 66*(2), 358–384. Organizational identification: A meta-analysis.

Sarder, M. B., & Mustaqeem, M. (2024). Digital branding in higher education: Strategies and challenges. *International Journal of Educational Management, 38*(4), 912–928. (PDF) Branding Digital in Higher Education Institutions: Theoretical Contexts of Digital Branding in Universities

Sato, T. (2017). Intersubjectivity and collective sensemaking in organizations. *Organization Studies, 38*(12), 1721–1740. (PDF) Sensemaking in organizations: by Karl E. Weick (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications, 1995), 231 pp.

Saunders, P. Thornhill, A., & Lewis, P. (2019). *Research methods for business students* (8th ed). Pearson.

Saunders, M., Lewis, P., & Thornhill, A. (2023). *Research methods for business students* (9th ed.). Pearson. (PDF) Research Methods for Business Students

Sheikh, S. a. H. E., Assaad, R. Y., Halim, Y. T., & Emara, O. a. M. (2024). The impact of sustainable internal branding on teaching staff's commitment: Application on private higher education institutions. *Journal of Marketing for Higher Education*, 1–26. https://doi.org/10.1080/08841241.2024.2301773

Shenton, A. K. (2004). Strategies for ensuring trustworthiness in qualitative research projects. Education for Information, 22(2), 63–75. https://doi.org/10.3233/efi-2004-22201

Snadrou, D., & Haoucha, M. (2024). Understanding the crucial role of brand image in the students' higher education institution choice: A review of the literature of higher education branding. *Journal of Marketing Research and Case Studies*. https://doi.org/10.5171/2024.224523

Stoica, D., Patriche, C., David, S., Beldiman, C. M., & Bălănică, C. M. D. (2025). Knowledge-driven reputation management in higher education institutions. *Journal of Innovation & Knowledge*, *10*(6), 100811. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jik.2025.100811

Starbuck, W. H., & Milliken, F. J. (1988). Executives' perceptual filters: What they notice and how they make sense. In D. C. Hambrick (Ed.), *The executive effect: Concepts and methods for studying top managers* (pp. 35–65). JAI Press. (PDF) Executives"Perceptual Filters: What They Notice and How They Make Sense

Ting, H., Memon, M. A., Thurasamy, R., & Cheah, J. (2025). Snowball Sampling: A review and guidelines for survey research. Asian Journal of Business Research, 15(1), 1–15. https://doi.org/10.14707/ajbr.250186

UNESCO. (2025). Global flow of tertiary-level students. UNESCO Institute for Statistics. World Education Statistics 2025 | Institute for Statistics (UIS)

Vallaster, C., & de Chernatony, L. (2006). Internal brand building and structuration: The role of leadership. European Journal of Marketing, 40(7/8), 761–784. (PDF) Internal brand building and structuration: the role of leadership

Wæraas, A., & Solbakk, M. N. (2008). Defining the essence of a university: lessons from higher education branding. *Higher Education*, *57*(4), 449–462. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10734-008-9155-z

Wagner, T., Lutz, R. J., & Weitz, B. A. (2009). Corporate hypocrisy: Overcoming the threat of inconsistent corporate social responsibility perceptions. *Journal of Marketing, 73*(6), 77–91. (PDF) Corporate Hypocrisy: Overcoming the Threat of Inconsistent Corporate Social Responsibility Perceptions

Weick, K. E. (1995). *Sensemaking in organizations*. SAGE Publications. (PDF) Sensemaking in organizations: by Karl E. Weick (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications, 1995), 231 pp.

Weick, K. E., Sutcliffe, K. M., & Obstfeld, D. (2005). Organizing and the process of sensemaking. *Organization Science*, *16*(4), 409–421. https://doi.org/10.1287/orsc.1050.0133

Whisman, R. (2009). Internal branding: A university's most valuable intangible asset. *International Journal of Educational Management, 23*(6), 478–489. Whisman, R. (2009). Internal branding: A university's most valuable intangible asset. International Journal of Educational Management, 23(6), 478–489. - Google Search

Yaping, X., Huong, N. T. T., Nam, N. H., Quyet, P. D., Khanh, C. T., & Anh, D. T. H. (2023). University brand: A systematic literature review. *Heliyon*, *9*(6), e16825. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.heliyon.2023.e16825

Zhao, L. (2024). Digital transformation and institutional identity in higher education: The role of social media. *Computers & Education, 210*, 104967. (PDF) Digital Transformation and Digital Leadership in Higher Education Institutions: Insights from the Literature

8. Appendices

Appendix 1: E-Mail Template

Dear Sir or Madam,

We are Nora Mohamed and Zowda Muhamoud Ali, master's students in the Digital Business program at Jönköping University. We are currently working on our master's thesis, which explores how internal stakeholders make sense of digital branding strategies at Jönköping International Business School (JIBS).

As part of our research, we are conducting interviews with employees and students to understand their perspectives on the institution's digital communication and branding. We were wondering if you would be willing to participate in a short interview for our study. The interview would take approximately 30-60 minutes and will be conducted via Microsoft Teams. It would focus on your experiences and views regarding digital communication and branding within the institution.

Your insights would be very valuable for our research. We would be happy to schedule the interview at a time that is convenient for you.

Participation will remain confidential and the information will only be used for academic purposes.

Thank you very much for considering our request.

Best regards,
Nora Mohamed & Zowda Muhamoud Ali

Appendix 2: GDPR Consent Form



JÖNKÖPING UNIVERSITY

Jönköping International Business School

GDPR Thesis Study Consent Form

Required by European Union General Data Protection Regulation 2016/679

GDPR Consent for the thesis *"A Single Case Study Investigation of Internal Digital Branding in Higher Education Institutions"*

Please tick the appropriate boxes	**Yes**	**No**
Taking part in the study		
I consent to JIBS processing my personal data in accordance with current data protection legislation and the data delivered.	□	□
I consent voluntarily to be a participant in this study and understand that I can refuse to answer questions and I can withdraw from the study at any time, without having to give a reason.	□	□

My signature below indicates that I choose to take part in the thesis study and consent to JIBS treating my personal data in accordance with current data protection legislation and the data delivered.

_____ _____ _____

Name of participant (IN CAPITALS) Signature Date

Thesis contact details for further information

[Nora Mohamed, +46769458704, mono21di@student.ju.se**]**

[Zowda Ali Muhamoud, +46737623648, alzo21rm@student.ju.se**]**



JÖNKÖPING UNIVERSITY
Jönköping International Business School

Participant Information Sheet template

You are being invited to take part in a thesis study. Before you decide whether or not to take part, it is important for you to understand why the research is being done and what it will involve. Please take time to read the following information carefully.'

What is the purpose of the study collecting personal data?
The objective of this study is to explore how internal stakeholders interpret digital branding strategies at Jönköping International Business School (JIBS). The research aims to understand the perceptions of employees and students regarding the institution's digital communication and branding efforts. This master's thesis utilizes a qualitative single-case study approach. Data will be gathered through interviews with both employees and students. The research project will span approximately four months. The insights obtained from these interviews will enhance our understanding of internal stakeholders' views on digital branding within higher education institutions.
'It is entirely up to you to decide whether or not to take part. If you decide to do so, you will be given this information sheet to keep and will be asked to give your consent.' All the information that we collect about you during the course of the research will be kept strictly confidential. You will not be able to be identified in any ensuing reports or publications.'

Under GDPR you have the following rights over your personal data:

- ***The right to be informed**. You must be informed if your personal data is being used.*
- ***The right of access**. You can ask for a copy of your data by making a 'subject access request'.*
- ***The right to rectification.** You can ask for your data held to be corrected.*
- ***The right to erasure**. You can ask for your data to be deleted.*
- ***The right to restrict processing**. You can limit the way an organisation uses your personal data if you are concerned about the accuracy of the data or how it is being used.*
- ***The right to data portability**. You have the right to get your personal data from an organisation in a way that is accessible and machine-readable. You also have the right to ask an organisation to transfer your data to another organisation.*
- ***The right to object**. You have the right to object to the use of your personal data in some circumstances. You have an absolute right to object to an organisation using your data for direct marketing.*

- ***How your data is processed using automated decision making and profiling***. *You have the right not to be subject to a decision that is based solely on automated processing if the decision affects your legal rights or other equally important matters; to understand the reasons behind decisions made about you by automated processing and the possible consequences of the decisions, and to object to profiling in certain situations, including for direct marketing purposes.*

JÖNKÖPING UNIVERSITY
Jönköping International
Business School

You should also know that you may contact the data protection officer if you are unhappy about the way your data or your participation in this study are being treated at dpo@ju.se

Thank you for reading this information sheet and for considering whether to take part in this research study.'

Contact details for further information

Thesis supervisor __Naveed Akhter_____ naveed.akther@ju.se

Thesis student __Nora Mohamed _____ mono21di@student.ju.se

Thesis student __Zowda Muhamoud Ali __ alzo21rm@student.ju.se

Appendix 3: Interview Guide for employees and students

Interview Guide - Employees

Introductory questions

1. What is your position at Jönköping International Business School, and how long have you been employed there?
2. What are your primary responsibilities in your current role?
3. How much do you engage with students or other stakeholders within the institution?
4. Do you engage with the university's online communication channels, such as the website, social media accounts, or internal platforms?
5. How would you characterize JIBS as an institution in terms of its identity or core principles?

Key questions

6. How would you describe the way JIBs communicate itself through its digital platforms?
(Follow up)- Could you share some examples of the platforms or communication channels that stand out to you?

7. What kind of identity or image do you believe the organization is attempting to communicate through its digital presence?

8. How aware are you of the university's digital branding or communication strategies?
(Follow-up) How do employees typically find out about these strategies?

9. How do employees perceive and react to the university's digital branding initiatives, in your opinion?
(Follow-up)- Are there any circumstances in which the internal reality and the digital image are different?

10. In your opinion, how well does the university's digital image represent what it's like to work or study at JIBs?
(Follow-up)- Are there any instances that you can think of when the digital representation aligns well with internal experiences?
(Follow-up)- Are there instances in which the internal reality and the digital image are different?

11. What role do you think employees have in creating or enhancing the university's brand?

(Follow-up)- Do you think internal stakeholders influence how the university is viewed externally?
12. What difficulties, in your opinion, do universities encounter when communicating their identity through digital platforms?

13. In the future, what improvements do you think universities could make in their digital communication or branding strategies?

Interview Guide - Students

Introductory questions

1. How long have you been a student at Jönköping International Business School?

2. Which program are you now enrolled in?

3. Why did you decide to pursue your education at JIBs?

4. Prior to your arrival at JIBs, how did you first find out about the university?

Key questions

5. How often do you engage with the university's online platforms, like its website and social media channels?
6. How would you characterize the perception of JIBs that you get from its online channels?

   (if necessary, follow up)
   Which online resources do you utilize or observe most frequently?

7. How did the digital communication of the university affect your impression of JIBs prior to your enrollment?

   (Follow up)
   Before you arrived, were there any expectations raised by the university's online presence?

8. In your view, how accurately does JIBS's digital representation capture your actual experiences as a student?

   (Follow up)
   Could you provide an instance where your experience and the online image align?

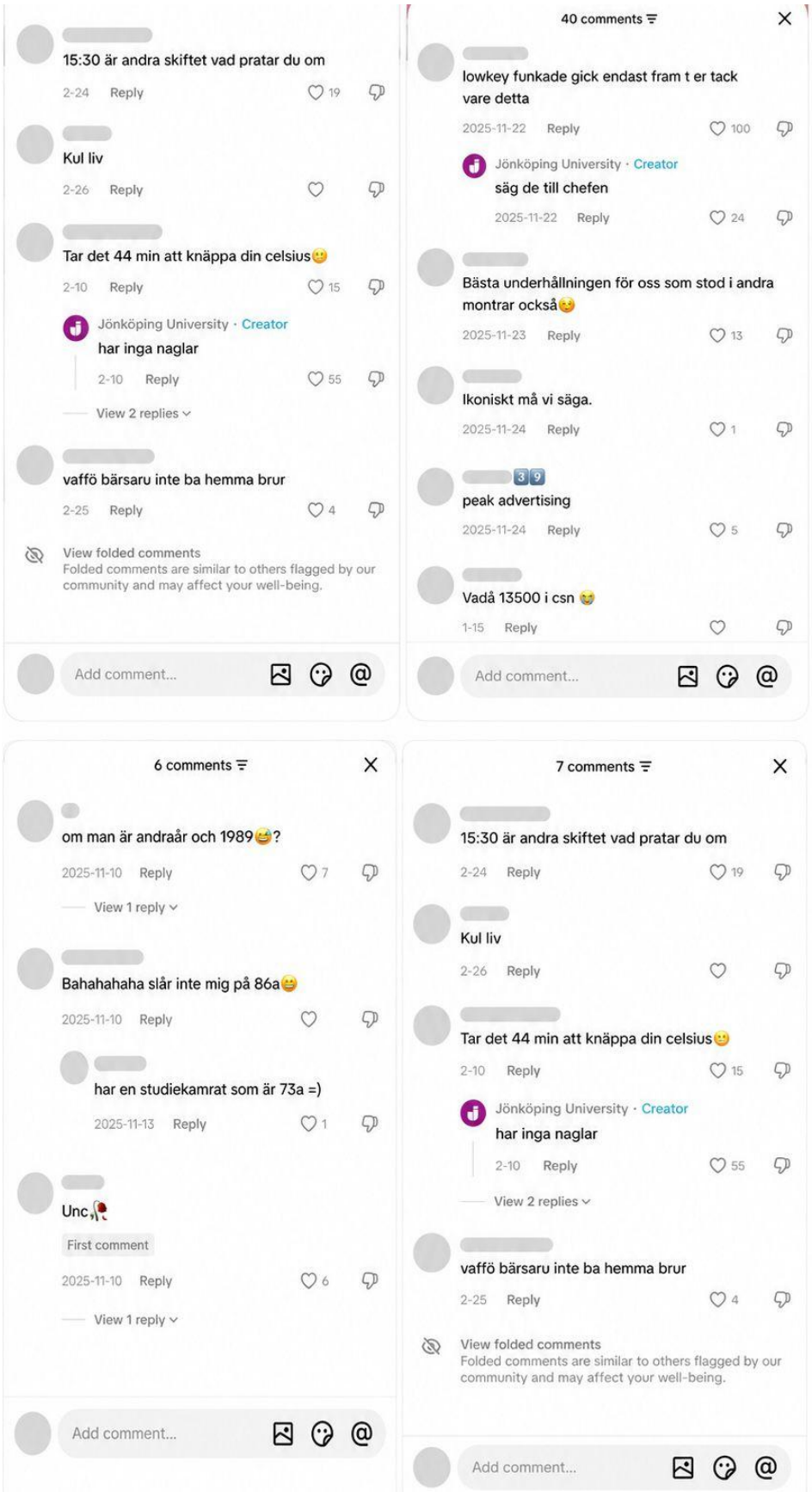
9. Are there occasions when the university's online image opposes your experiences as a student?

(Follow up)
What effect does that have on how you view the institution?

10. From your point of view, what part do students play in influencing the university's image or reputation?

11. Do you believe that students have an impact on how people view the university, for instance through personal recommendations or social media?
12. In your opinion, what improvements could the university enhance regarding its digital communication with students?

Appendix 4: More Screenshots of social media comments



Comments

[redacted] 5w · ❤ by author
Every damn time 💀
Reply
6

[redacted] 5w
Already cooked 💀
Reply
4

[redacted] 5w · ❤ by author
Panic 🤡
Reply
5

[redacted] 5w · ❤ by author
legends say he's still trying to find the exam
Reply
24

[redacted] 6w · ❤ by author
hahaha this is so true.
and very safe..
Reply
1

[redacted] 6w
damn true 😂 🙌
Reply

[redacted] 6w · ❤ by author
Haha so true :(😂
Reply
1

9. AI Declaration

We hereby declare that this thesis represents my/our own work.
We declare that we have obtained the necessary ethical approval (e.g., GDPR) and acknowledged my/our obligations and the rights of the participants/respondents in the research. We have read and applied the Jönköping University's current research ethics guidelines with regards to the use of artificial intelligence (AI) tools in this work as presented in the Course Guide. During the preparation of this work the author(s) used the following AI tools and the purpose for their use. The authors used the following AI tools and objectives in the preparation of this work:
ChatGPT was used to fix grammatical mistakes, organize the bibliography alphabetically, enhance the text's readability and clarity, offer feedback on the coherence and structure of the report, and anonymize our screenshots comments.
AI Summarizer was used to facilitates the synthesis of large amounts of information by effectively summarizing long articles.
Grammarly was used to help with producing clear, concise, and error - free writing.
AI Citation Generator was used to ensure correct source attribution by producing citations in APA format.
Microsoft Teams Voice-to-Text Transcription Tool was used to transcribe audio recordings and interviews accurately, thereby ensuring documentation and saving times.

As authors, we have reviewed and edited the content as needed and take full responsibility for the content of the thesis.

Signature: ____Nora Mohamed_____
Date: ___20/5/2026_____
Signature: ___Zowda Muhamuod Ali_____
Date: ____20/5/2026_____